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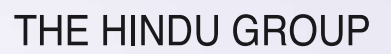
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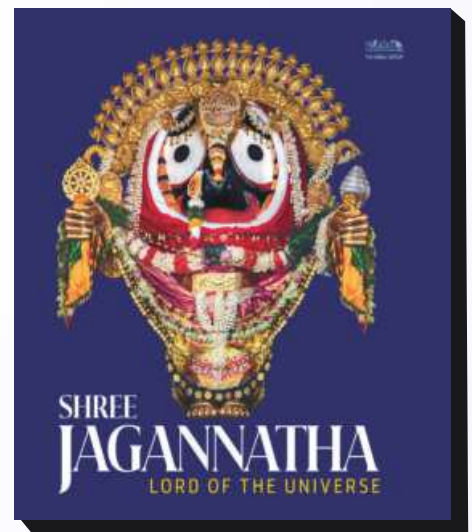
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NEWS » PAGE 10

LABOUR IN THE LURCH
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WORLD » PAGE 14



CRIMINAL RECORDS
NCRB's DNA database crosses 1 lakh entries
NEWS » PAGE 10

DESIGN CHOICES
The lack of accountability within the NTA
Looking at the costs of institutional failures
OPINION » PAGE 9



ROARING BACK
Spain proves too hot for Saudi Arabia
SPORT » PAGE 15

NEARBY



State govt. urged to back critical mineral projects

CHENNAI Union Minister for Coal and Mines G. Kishan Reddy has appealed to the Tamil Nadu government and the people for support in the acquisition of land for projects to mine critical minerals. » PAGE 6

HC takes up case to protect people from stray dogs

CHENNAI The Madras High Court has taken up *suo motu* a plea to ensure that Supreme Court orders for protecting people from stray dogs are strictly implemented. » PAGE 6

EDUCATIONPLUS » PAGE 2, 17

Two die in ammonia gas leak at T.N. seafood unit

Over 60 people, mostly migrant workers, hospitalised after leak; CM announces three-member inquiry panel, ₹2 lakh for kin of the dead, both from Odisha; company's owner, manager arrested

R. Srikanth
Deepa H. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

Two migrant workers from Odisha were killed and more than 60 hospitalised after an ammonia gas leak at a shrimp processing unit in Tiruvallur district of Tamil Nadu on Sunday. Of those in hospital, 23 have been admitted to the Intensive Care Unit.

The Tiruvallur district police said the private company, Peter & Paul Seafood Exports Pvt. Ltd., at Kannagiper village near Periyapalayam was engaged in processing shrimps and exporting them.

At the time of the accident, there were 67 people at the site, mostly migrant women, who worked in the factory and lived in the



National Disaster Response Force personnel at the seafood unit in Tiruvallur district of Tamil Nadu after the gas leak on Sunday. PTI

accommodation provided within the premises. The deceased have been identified as Jumani Juang and B. Malothi.

The police arrested the proprietor of the company and the factory manager, who both have a case pending against them for previous violations of industrial safety norms.

During inspection, it was found the company did not have a suitable alarm system, a fire hydrant, or a Form 12 register for the Employee State Insurance scheme.

The company had also not obtained a revised plan approval when new equipment was installed, including an ice flaking machine.

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay set up a three-member panel to probe into the incident and ordered ₹2 lakh each to be paid to the families of the two dead workers. An official statement said the panel had been tasked to submit an interim report in 24 hours and final report in three days. To prevent the recurrence of such accidents, the government has mandated immediate joint inspections of all hazardous industries, it added.

Mr. Vijay also directed that the bodies of the victims be transported to their native places for final rites at the Tamil Nadu government's expense.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10
RELATED REPORT ON
» PAGE 6

More than 20 lakh take NEET re-test under heavy security

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

More than 20 lakh candidates appeared for the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (Under graduate) re-test at 5,440 centres across India and 14 centres abroad on Sunday, the National Testing Agency (NTA) said.

While the NTA has not stated the exact number of students who appeared for the re-test, it is likely that the number is lower than the 22.05 lakh who had appeared for the test in May, which was later cancelled following a paper leak.

Around seven lakh officials, including police teams, observers, and examination staff, were mobilised across the country to conduct the examination, with the NTA also drawing the support of the Central Armed Police Forces, the Department of Posts, the Department of Financial Services, the National Informatics Centre,



Take two: Medical aspirants appearing for the NEET re-test wait outside an examination centre in New Delhi on Sunday. R.V. MOORTHY

and the Indian Air Force. While the re-test, held in 13 languages, including Hindi and English, remained NCERT-focused, students found the paper more demanding than the cancelled test due to a longer, more calculation-heavy physics section.

Many students said physics was the hardest section while chemistry was moderately challenging. Biology questions were largely NCERT-based, they added.

The re-test also came with its share of academic, financial, and psychological hurdles for those who chose to take it, with some aspirants and their families flagging commuting difficulties in reaching the examination centres.

Last-minute centre-specific rule changes and security checks led to confusion, with some students denied entry due to delays.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

Forward posture



Army personnel take part in a yoga session in Ladakh. The International Day of Yoga was observed on Sunday. PTI (REPORTS: PAGE 12)

India-U.S. interim trade deal needs 'final touches': officials

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

With the U.S. Trade Representative (USTR), Jamieson Greer, set to visit India this week, two separate sources in the government have told *The Hindu* that an interim trade deal required only "final touches" and that the U.S. was keen on seeing a deal in place.

Mr. Greer is scheduled to meet Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal and other officials during his two-day visit. However, while the provisions of the deal are nearing completion, Mr. Goyal has indicated that its implementation will still require the U.S. to first finalise various tariffs.



Jamieson Greer

"USTR Greer is scheduled to visit India on June 23 and 24," a senior Commerce Ministry official confirmed, adding that Mr. Greer would meet Mr. Goyal and that the discussions would be centred on "giving final touches to the framework deal".

The USTR's visit comes weeks after Assistant USTR

Brendan Lynch visited New Delhi from June 1 to 4.

Mr. Goyal on Saturday indicated that recent U.S. investigations on forced labour and fresh tariff announcements were a major reason for the delay in finalising the agreement.

"We cannot implement the FTA [free trade agreement] until we secure a competitive advantage," he told presspersons. "The issue currently pending is that our duties need to be lower compared to those of competing nations; once this is settled, the trade agreement will be implemented."

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

India-EU FTA to be signed by December, says Goyal

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

India and the European Union will sign the free trade agreement (FTA) by December, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Sunday. The two sides concluded negotiations in January. The deal is expected to be implemented by February-March next year, Mr. Goyal said at an event in Mumbai.

"Now, with almost zero duty, almost the entire European market will be open for us," he said.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 10

Opportunity to 'turn over a new leaf' with Iran, says Vance as two sides gather for talks in Switzerland

Associated Press
OBBUERGEN

U.S. Vice-President J.D. Vance said on Sunday that there was an opportunity to "turn over a new leaf" with Iran as the two sides launched talks aimed at building out the interim deal to end the war in Iran reached by the two sides last week.

Mr. Vance is holding talks with Iran's parliamentary Speaker, Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf, and Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi, at a Swiss mountainside resort near Lake Lucerne. The Vice-President was joined by special envoy Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner. Mediators from Pakistan and Qatar were in the room for the direct engagement.



The Iranian team, including Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi and Speaker Mohammed Bagher Ghalibaf, in Switzerland on Sunday. AP

The U.S. is looking to get Iran locked into negotiations over its nuclear programme amid concerns it may be used for military purposes, which Iran denies. Mr. Vance also wants to push Tehran to commit to keeping open the Strait of Hormuz.

But the ongoing conflict

in Lebanon between Israel and Hezbollah, the Iran-backed militant group, continues to threaten to derail the peace efforts.

"The question before us now is how much more can we accomplish together? Can we turn over a new leaf?" Mr. Vance said in brief comments as the

talks, dubbed the "Lake Lucerne Summit", got under way. "Can we change relations in the Middle East permanently, or do we go back to doing things the old way, which is not our preference, but is certainly very much something that can happen," he said.

Iran's state-run IRNA news agency suggested that talks have "entered a difficult phase" after what it described as an "insulting" statement by U.S. President Donald Trump. The U.S. President earlier made multiple provocative warnings to Tehran, including to "hit Iran very hard again" if it did not stop Hezbollah from "causing trouble".

Iran later warned the U.S. to be careful with its statements. "They would

do better to be careful with their statements; our armed forces are ready to respond... No matter what they say, we are the ones who act," Mr. Ghalibaf said.

While Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian said before the meeting that the Islamic Republic will maintain its right to a nuclear programme, the country's state broadcaster said that nuclear programme had not been discussed on Sunday. "No negotiations regarding Iran's nuclear programme took place during the 80-minute first round of talks," it said, adding that it was not clear whether the talks would continue or be suspended.

'TROOPS FREE TO ACT'
» PAGE 14

Maritime sector a major engine of economic growth, says Modi

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday said no nation could emerge as a major power without strong maritime capabilities.

He was speaking at an event here after commissioning three indigenously built naval ships – *INS Dunagiri*, an advanced stealth frigate; *INS Sanshodhak*, a survey vessel (large); and the *INS Agray*, an anti-submarine warfare shallow watercraft.

Describing the event as a milestone in the journey towards "an *Aatmanirbhar Bharat*, a secure India, and a developed India", Mr. Modi said the government viewed the maritime sector not as an isolated in-



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Chief of the Naval Staff Admiral Krishna Swaminathan at the ceremony in Kolkata on Sunday. PTI

dustory but as a major engine of employment and economic growth. "The country whose maritime strength is robust, its economic and strategic influence will be equally robust. India is preparing itself for this," he said, asserting that India did not wish to be merely a buyer in the defence sector.

"The strength of the na-

tion's military cannot be measured by its dependence on global markets but by its ability to become self-reliant. India seeks to become a producer and a manufacturer, because nations that manufacture become decisive players on the global stage," he said.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

NEET re-test: Students find paper moderate, expect lower cut-off

The exam held on May 3 was cancelled after allegations of a question paper leak. Officials say 1,42,489 candidates registered for the exam in T.N.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The retest of the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET) UG 2026 was conducted by the National Testing Agency (NTA) on Sunday for which 1.4 lakh students had registered across 307 centres, spread across more than 31 districts in Tamil Nadu. Many students were upset as the paper was lengthy, especially the physics portion. The NEET-UG, originally held on May 3, was cancelled on May 12 after allegations of a question paper leak. According to officials, in Tamil Nadu, as many as 1,42,489 candidates had registered to write the exam. In Chennai, 22,128 students registered to write the exam at 43 centres. While many students found the paper to be moderate, some found it tough.

Difficulty level
“Though I had taken up private coaching, the re-exam paper was tough. The little hope I had after taking up the first exam is lost now. I couldn’t even prepare the same way as the cancellation news was very frustrating and stressful,” said Pradeepa. A, who had attempted the NEET exam for the first time.

The stress and fear



Fresh attempt: A total of 22,128 students registered to take the NEET-UG re-test at 43 centres across Chennai. R. RAGU

caused by the anxiety of the difficulty level of the paper, compared to the May 3 exam, left many unable to study properly for the re-exam. “As a family we were stressed that my daughter would have to take up the exam. She couldn’t sleep because of the fear, which impacted her studies. She was happy with her first performance, the second one not so much,” said Manjula. J, mother of a NEET aspirant. Devi (name changed) who had taken up the exam for the third time said she lost hope of becoming

a doctor. “The exam I took on May 3 was good. I had immense hope of making the cut off. Now the paper was difficult, lot of stress and little time to process. I am not going to take up any exam organised by the National Testing Agency,” she said. Some students pointed out that the cut off might decrease. Ashish Matthew, who wrote NEET for the first time, said that the paper was difficult. “But this might result in a low cut-off which means more chances of selections, which could be beneficial,” he said.



Around 100 musicians performed at the World Music Day Gig Marathon at Pondy Bazaar in the city on Sunday. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

Hundreds gather for a 15-hour celebration on World Music Day

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Sixty-three-year-old Rajalakshmi Parameshwaran was clapping and dancing to live gaana songs alongside hundreds of music lovers at the World Music Day Gig marathon 2026, organised by the Greater Chennai Corporation in association with On The Streets (OTS) of Chennai at the Pedestrian Plaza in Pondy Bazaar on Sunday. “I have been coming to this street music community every weekend, and this is where I met most of my best friends. Moreover, this is a reminder you can still have fun after your 50s,” she says. As part of World Music Day celebrations, the event that started at 7 a.m. and continued until 10 p.m. had a line-up that included indie music, sing-alongs, classical fusion, *parai*, Tamil, Hindi, Malayalam film songs, a girl band, a kids’ band, along with yoga and art activities. About a hundred musicians performed at the event.

“A lot of things happened today that brought us joy. A person with disability came all the way from Potheri in his wheelchair and stayed here listening to the music from morning,” says Senthil Raj, founder of OTS. Meanwhile, Salma, who leads the Tea Kada boys performed folk songs on stage. “Not everyone can afford expensive concerts even though they may dream of attending one. But here, on the streets, we are doing concerts for free. Music is for everyone, and music should be inclusive,” she adds. Another artist from the girl band Triad, Anbumathi (Avox), says these mini concerts on the streets is about enabling public spaces and building community. Co-founder of OTS, Krish, who also performed classical fusion with his band Anahata, says that they want to transform Chennai’s streets, beaches, and parks into cultural hubs. The event also included a classical open mic segment.

Labourer electrocuted on Anna Salai

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A 40-year-old man was electrocuted on Anna Salai on Saturday night. The police

said R. Ramesh was a labourer. On Saturday, he went home heavily drunk and slept outside his house. Later, he went to a vacant spot opposite his

house and was electrocuted when he touched a pillar box. He died on the spot. The Anna Salai police sent the body for a post-mortem examination.

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Under Thalapathy's Leadership...

Respectfully presented by
Hon'ble **Dr. V. K. Rajeev**
Minister for Environment and Climate Change
Government of Tamil Nadu
MLA, Thiruvadanai Constituency

Indira Nagar residents lament waterlogging due to Metro Rail work

Second Avenue has also been witnessing frequent sewage problems, as the sewer line has been affected by CMRL's work on the phase II project

CITY MATTERS

Sunitha Sekar
CHENNAI

For residents of Indira Nagar Second Avenue, it is not just damaged roads that have been troubling them. They have also been grappling with frequent sewage issues and waterlogging due to Chennai Metro Rail's work on the phase II project.

Residents allege that a portion of the storm-water drain that runs along the service road of the Second Avenue, which lies within the CMRL worksite, has been demolished.

As a result, water from the neighbouring localities flows into the service road, causing heavy waterlogging even during moderate rainfall, says Radha, a resident.

Since an alternative stormwater drain to divert rainwater into the Buckingham Canal was not created, residents say they experienced flooding even during the intermittent heavy showers that oc-



Flooding woes: Residents say a portion of the storm-water drain along the service road, which lies within the CMRL worksite (in picture), was demolished, leaving the road prone to inundation.

curred in April this year. Subsequently, Chennai Metro Rail's contractors pumped out the water.

Himachalan A., another resident, said the underground drainage network's flow too had been affected due to the ongoing work.

"As the sewer line has been affected by the work, we have experienced sewage overflow in our house on quite a few occasions. Every time, we have to run to them (Chennai Metro

Rail contractors) to set it right. Why can't they fix these issues permanently," he said.

Officials of the Chennai Metro Rail Limited say the stormwater drainage and sewer issues will be rectified.

"There is also an issue with the gradient of the drain, and hence, the waterlogging occurs. We need some time, but we will definitely resolve it," an official said.

The Hindu Bureau CHENNAI

On account of Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay's birthday, the Forest Department had announced free entry to the Arignar Anna Zoological Park on June 21 and 22.

On Sunday alone, the zoo saw a total of 17,182 visitors.

According to videos circulating on social media, many people complained

On Sunday alone, the Arignar Anna Zoological Park saw a total of 17,182 visitors

that only those who had online tickets were allowed to enter. However, a press release, which was issued later by the zoological park, said the visitors with pre-booked online tickets as well as those without

pre-booked tickets were allowed entry.

The release also said separate vehicle parking facility, free shuttle services, and wrist tags for children were made available.

About 70 visitors used the medical help desks, and ambulances facilities were set up within the zoo.

Forest staff, police personnel, Singappen Special Force, and volunteers were deployed to manage the crowd.



The Forest Department had announced free entry on June 21 and 22 to mark the Chief Minister's birthday. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

Naadhabrahmam honours musician Kanmony with 'Naadha Vinodhini' title

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Musician, teacher, researcher, and artist with disability S. Kanmony was conferred the title 'Naadha Vinodhini' by Naadhabrahmam United Gyan Academy here on Sunday.

The event was held on the occasion of International Music and Yoga Day and to mark the 25th year of Naadhabrahmam.

R. Seshasayee, Chairman, Asian Paints, said it was startling to see what Ms. Kanmony had accomplished so far.

Apart from the fact that

she had given 500 concerts and received a national award, she was also a painter. "How many of us can achieve this?" he asked.

That the sabha has been functioning for the last 25 years was a great feat, Mr. Seshasayee added.

On accepting the award, Ms. Kanmony said she was deeply honoured, and expressed her gratitude to her parents and family. She said this was not just a recognition but also a responsibility to continue her work and achieve more.

N. Subramanian, founder of Naadhabrahmam, also spoke on the occasion.



R. Seshasayee (right), Chairman, Asian Paints, conferring the 'Naadha Vinodhini' title on Carnatic vocalist S. Kanmony at the 25th year celebrations of Naadhabrahmam on Sunday. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

Residents, experts launch Pallikaranai Collective for conservation of wetland

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Oorvani Foundation and Chennai Wetlands Action Collective conducted a half-day consultation session, bringing together researchers, civic groups, and residents across the Pallikaranai watershed region of the Kovalam basin to identify concerns and strengthen collaboration.

Participants formed the Pallikaranai Collective during the session held at IIT-Madras Research Park on Saturday, and sought to develop a People's Charter for the Pallikaranai Watershed, which is critical to the city's ecological health.

S. Janakarajan, president of the South Asia Consortium for Interdisciplinary Water Resources Studies, said that stress on the ecosystem had been building up over the past few decades, with government agencies focusing on urban development.

Representatives of citizen groups discussed issues such as urbanisation, shrinking wetlands, sewage pollution, and flood risks

He said agencies such as the Greater Chennai Corporation, the Water Resources Department, and the Chennai Metropolitan Development Authority worked in silos.

Mr. Janakarajan further said that priority should be given to conserving water, and called for greater responsibility from developers in the waste management sector.

Radhakrishnan of Arappor Iyakkam said that the findings of the Thiruppagazh Committee report on flood mitigation measures had not yet been released publicly, and urged residents to seek accountability.

Dayanand Krishnan of Chitlapakkam Rising called for a comprehensive watershed-based map of the wetland, a release said.

Several concerns raised Deepak V. of Suzhal Arivom raised concerns over Metro Rail construction activities within the marsh, sewage pollution, and biodiversity loss.

T.D. Babu of Nizhal; N. Udhayarajan and Nandakumar of the International Centre for Clean Water at IIT-Madras Research Park; and Muthu Karthick of Care Earth Trust also addressed the session.

Around 15 representatives of citizen groups from areas such as Thalambur, Madambakkam, Velachery, Perumbakkam, Sholinganallur, Chitlapakkam, and Sembakkam discussed issues such as urbanisation, shrinking wetlands, sewage pollution, and flood-related risks across the watershed.

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OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

In Loving Memory of Shri S.K. Ramprasad



Shri S.K. Ramprasad
Passed away: 20.6.2026

A pioneering leader and a distinguished stalwart of the Indian flour milling industry, whose vision, wisdom, and unwavering commitment left an enduring mark on the industry and all who knew him.

His remarkable legacy, exemplary leadership, and invaluable contributions will continue to inspire generations to come.

May his eternal soul rest in peace and divine grace
With heartfelt condolences and profound respect,
Naga Limited, Dindigul

DEATH

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

27th ANNIVERSARY



Time rolls, but memories remain forever. In fond and loving memory of **Shri. P. S. BALASUBRAMANYAM** who left us for heavenly abode on 22 June 1999 *Fondly remembered by:* Pramila (Wife) Uma Eswaran (Daughter) Eswaran Sankaran (Son-in-law) Sathya Eswaran (Grandson) Prathna Sukheja

4th ANNIVERSARY



VASTU MASTER S.N. REDDY "YOU STILL REMAIN DEEP IN OUR HEARTS" Fondly remembered by **FRIENDS**

"For to me to live is Christ, and to die is gain."
- Philippians 1:21

With profound sorrow, we announce the passing of
Mrs. Saroji Pandian (79 years)
(wife of Late Mr. S.D.J. Pandian)
Retired Teacher, ICF Higher Secondary School,
and Director, Syncfusion Software,
who was called to be with the Lord on June 20, 2026.
Beloved wife, mother, grandmother, great-grandmother,
and aunt, cherished by family and friends.
The funeral service will be held at C.S.I. Immanuel Church,
35, Church Street, Anna Nagar West, Thangam Colony, Chennai - 600 040,
on Monday, June 22, 2026, at 2:00 p.m.
This will be followed by the burial at Kilpauk Cemetery.
Deeply mourned by
her sons, daughters-in-law, grandchildren, great-grandchild, relatives, and friends.
Contact: 98406 50500

INBRIEF



Walkathon held to raise awareness on elder abuse

HattaKatta Tech Private Limited, an AI-powered preventive senior care platform, organised a walkathon at the Besant Nagar Beach on Sunday to mark World Elder Abuse Awareness Day and highlight the importance of the dignity, safety, and well-being of senior citizens. The walk brought together caregivers, healthcare professionals, and community organisations, who pledged to work towards preventing elder abuse and promoting a culture of respect and inclusion. The event was presided over by V.S. Natarajan, founder of V.S.N. Geriatric Foundation. Abirami Premnath, founder of C2H Naturopathy, was present.

TVK draws flak over video of functionaries disrupting class

A video of a group of TVK functionaries in Kancheepuram district entering a government school and allegedly disrupting a class to display the official portrait of Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay was circulated widely on social media platforms, drawing criticism. Sources said the group from Uthiramerur went to Thalavarampoondi Panchayat Union Primary School on June 19 with the official portrait of Mr. Vijay. They were also seen interacting with the students. DMK functionaries submitted a representation to the Kancheepuram Collector and officials of the School Education Department, seeking action against those involved in the incident.

Minister inspects monsoon preparedness measures

Artificial Intelligence, Information Technology and Digital Services Minister R. Kumar on Sunday inspected monsoon preparedness works in Adyar zone, and directed officials to take precautionary measures before the onset of the Northeast monsoon. The Minister reviewed desilting and waste removal works being carried out in silt traps on Parameswari Nagar Road. At the Adyar estuary, he held discussions on measures to remove sandbars and ensure the free flow of rainwater. He also inspected the removal of water hyacinth from Veerangal Odai in Velachery.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper. thehindu.com) carries explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (June 22, Monday), the following articles are available:

■ Decoupling footpaths from accidents newsth.live/footpathsafety

■ Biochar offers a way to turn India's farm smoke into 'black gold' newsth.live/biochar

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Perambur, R.K. Nagar residents complain of pollution caused by fire at dumpyard

The public health risk is high for over 10,000 families in Ward 41, says councillor B. Vimala. Residents demand that the GCC improve surveillance at the Kodungaiyur dumpyard. Corporation plans to hold a meeting with Fire and Rescue Services to install sprinklers to prevent fires in dumpyards

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Following a fire in the Kodungaiyur dumpyard on Sunday, the residents of five wards in the Perambur and Dr. Radhakrishnan Nagar Assembly constituencies in north Chennai have complained of pollution and other public health issues.

Ward 41 councillor B. Vimala said she had received complaints from many residents in her ward.

Ash particles in food “Residents of Ezhil Nagar, Chandrasekar Nagar, and MGR Nagar in ward 41 were among those who had complained of pollution. Children and the elderly have been the hardest-hit. Residents have also complained of eye irritation.



Health hazard: Residents of wards 34, 35, and 37 in the Perambur constituency, and wards 38 and 41 in the R.K. Nagar constituency had complained of pollution caused by the fire. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Ash particles have been found in food. The public health risk is high for over 10,000 families in the ward,” she said.

Federation of North Chennai Residents’ Welfare Association president T.K. Shanmugham said the residents of wards 34, 35,

and 37 in the Perambur Assembly constituency, and wards 38 and 41 in the Dr. Radhakrishnan Nagar Assembly constituency had



The fire occurred most likely due to methane gas and atmospheric heat. It took three hours to put out the fire

G.S. SAMEERAN
GCC Commissioner

complained of pollution caused by the fire. “Residents have demanded that the Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) increase surveillance to prevent fires in the dumpyard. The GCC should take action against the officials responsible for the fire,” he added.

“The fire started around 9.30 a.m. It occurred most likely due to methane gas and atmospheric heat. The

fire was reported below the HT lines of TANTRANSCO. It took three hours to put out the fire. Smoke management took another two hours. Five fire tenders, 10 water lorries, and a few earthmovers were pressed into service. The HT line was switched off, and alternative supply was provided to those substations during the operations. The GCC Joint Commissioner Health, the Regional Deputy Commissioner North, the District Fire Officer, and the Managing Director of TANTRANSCO were on spot to coordinate the work. We are planning to conduct a meeting with the Fire and Rescue Services to install sprinklers to prevent fires in dumpyards,” GCC Commissioner G.S. Sameeran said.

Kasimedu harbour springs back to life after lifting of fishing ban; around 600 tonnes of fish sold

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

After a hiatus of over 60 days, the market at the Kasimedu harbour came back to life early on Sunday morning, selling around 600 tonnes of fish.

The auctioning of wholesale fish began at 2 a.m., and retail sales started at 5 a.m., attracting a large number of buyers.

The annual fishing ban had come to an end on the midnight of June 15, and boats that had set out on four to five-day trips returned on Saturday night and Sunday morning.

“A section of the boats had been returning daily since Tuesday, after fishing for a few hours. They brought back 250 to 400 tonnes of fish every day. Of a total of 800 mechanised boats that dock at the harbour, 50 are under repair, 600 have been going fishing, and 120 returned with fish on Sunday,” a source in the Fisheries Department said.

Nominal prices The boats brought back mullets, *vaala meen*, octopus,



Open for business: Hundreds of people thronged the Kasimedu wholesale fish market in Chennai on Sunday to buy fresh catch, after the 61-day annual fishing ban ended. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

anchovies, small-sized *paarai*, and shrimp.

“The prices were nominal. They were neither too high nor too low, making the fishermen and the buyers happy,” a trader said.

Fish from Kasimedu is taken in baskets by women to local markets in the city.

More varieties Fishermen showed off large-

sized grouper fish, also called *Kalavaan*, and sharks caught in their nets.

“Earlier, such sharks, *Thirukkai*, and *Kola* would not be consumed the way fish were. They would be cut into pieces and salted (made into *uppu kandam*) and sent to Sri Lanka. Now, people are consuming these varieties, too,” fishing community leader M.D. Dayalan said.

Continue welfare schemes for Sri Lankan Tamil refugees: Stalin

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

DMK president M.K. Stalin has urged the State government to continue the welfare schemes implemented by the previous DMK government for Sri Lankan Tamil refugees.

In a social media post referring to the documentary, *Faceless People*, by R.K. Radhakrishnan, he recalled the welfare measures taken by the DMK government for Sri Lankan Tamils living in

camp. Mr. Stalin said the DMK government had constructed more than 7,000 houses for Sri Lankan Tamil refugees, and implemented several other welfare schemes. He pointed out that DMK MPs had repeatedly raised the issues faced by the community in Parliament.

“The DMK also approached the Supreme Court, seeking citizenship rights for Sri Lankan Tamils,” he said.

Mr. Stalin said he had written to the Prime Minister, urging that citizenship be granted to Sri Lankan Tamils.

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PERSONAL

CHANGE OF NAME

I, RENU Chauhan D/O Amar Singh Chauhan, R/o No.133, 1st Floor, Quaid E Millath Road, Triplicane, Chennai, Tamil Nadu – 600005 Have changed my Religion from Hinduism To Islam Religion wef– 18/02/2020, also changed my name to Nazmeen

I, ROSHNI Rao/ B Roshni, d/o: Ar-cot Krishnarao Balvinayak Rao, r/o: Tower 7, Apt No 601, North Town, Stephens Road, Otteri, Perambur Barracks, Chennai, Tamilnadu –600012. Have Changed My Name To Roshni Balvinayak Rao.

I, LATHA SUMANGALI Cadambi Ravi born on 16.2.1964 residing at 3C, Crescent Park Apartments, No. 11, Crescent Park Street, T.Nagar, Chennai-600017 shall henceforth be known as Latha Ravi.

I, SMT. Jothilakshmi Vishnu Prakash, W/o Vishnu Prakash and D/o Paramasivam, born on 24/06/1975, residing at B-22, Aihant, Amara Apartments, Poonamallee High Road, Goparasalanur, Chennai-56, shall henceforth be known as Paramasivam Jothilakshmi

I, Kavitha, D/O of S. Vijayakrishnan, residing at 2247, Sakthi Bhavanam, KH Road, Ayanavaram, Chennai-23, known as Kavitha Ajith after marriage, has changed my name to Kavitha Vijayakrishnan (Aadhaar No: 926588954625) after my divorce in April 2016.

I, ARUDHRAN, S/o. Prasanna Kumar R, Born on 10.02.2006, residing at No.33/2, Bharathi Salai, Triplicane, Chennai-600005, shall henceforth be known as ARUDHRAN P. – Arudhran

PUBLIC NOTICE

PUBLIC NOTICE
NOTICE IS HEREBY GIVEN to the general public at large that we are investigating the rights, title and interest of the 1. Ajay Kumar Agarwal, S/o. Anand Prakash Agarwal, 2. Om Prakash Agarwal, S/o. Sri Beni Gopal Agarwal and 3. Amit Kumar Agarwal, S/o. Anand Prakash Agarwal (landowners) in respect of their respective lands more particularly described in the Schedule hereunder, admeasuring 02 Acres and 27 Cents, situated at Adayalamattu Village, Poonamallee Taluk, Tiruvallur District (hereinafter referred to as Schedule Property), which our client proposes to purchase.
Any person(s) having/asserting any right, title, claim or interest of any nature whatsoever over the Schedule Property or in possession of the original documents and/or having any objection(s) of any manner whatsoever to the sale of the Schedule Property, are hereby called upon to notify the undersigned in writing with documentary proof within Fourteen (14) days from the date of publication of this notice. Any claims or objections received thereafter shall be deemed forfeited/voided and shall not be entertained in any manner whatsoever.
Description of Schedule Property
All that piece and parcel of lands situated at Adayalamattu Village, Poonamallee Taluk, Tiruvallur District lying within the Sub-Registration District of Chennai South Joint II and the Registration District of Chennai South, admeasuring to an extent of 02 Acres and 27 Cents, comprised in the following Survey Nos:

S.No.	Survey No.	Extent
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2.	105/5B	19 Cents
3.	107/3A2	26 Cents
4.	105/3A1	44 Cents
5.	105/4A	65 Cents
6.	105/3B	10 Cents
7.	105/4B	50 Cents
Total		02 Acres & 27 Cents

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LenCorp Legal Associates & Legal Consultants
Level-3, No.109&110, Salarn Square
Chambers Road, Chennai-18
E-mail: durga@lencorplegal.com
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PUBLIC NOTICE

My Client Mrs S. Sumathi, wife of Mr G. Sridhar, Residing at Flat No.601, Amara Amethyst Apartment, No.14, Padmavathi Road, Gopalapuram, Chennai-600006, intends purchasing, the property viz all that pieces and parcels of the land measuring a total extent of about Acre-96 Cents, comprised in present Survey Nos 244/1B1A, 244/1A1B, 244/1A2B1A and 244/1A2B1B and situated in Vichur (Village) as per revenue records now known as Vichur-II (Village), Ponneri Taluk, Thiruvallur District, from its present owners M/s Vijayakumar, Sumathi, Sakkarayammal and Maruthupandiyan on the stren-gth of the documents produced by them and the assurance given by the aforesaid persons that they are fully seized and well possessed of the said property free of all encumbrances, litiga-tions and liabilities whatsoever, Notice is hereby given that if anybody has any claim or objection or has any right whatsoever on the said property, he/ she/ they are required to lodge his/her/their claim along with legally sustainable documentary proof to my address given below by speed post within FIFTEEN days from this date and if no claim is received within the above referred period it will be presumed that the said Property is owned and held by the afore said present owners free all encumbrances, liabilities or litigations whatsoever

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INBRIEF



TNCC president urges Kharge to relieve him of the position

All India Congress Committee president Mallikarjun Kharge has reportedly asked Tamil Nadu Congress Committee (TNCC) president, K. Selvaperunthagai, to “wait” while he considers the latter’s request to be relieved of his duties as president of the State unit. Mr. Selvaperunthagai recently met Mr. Kharge in Bengaluru and conveyed his request. Even before the elections, he had expressed his desire to step down as TNCC president. Sources close to him said he had reached a stage where he was unable to function effectively as the head of the State unit. A close confidant of Mr. Selvaperunthagai said the swift cutting of ties with the DMK, a long-term ally and a committed anti-BJP force, in favour of an alliance with the TVK had left him disillusioned.

BJP flays govt. after students receive biscuits for breakfast

BJP Tamil Nadu president Nainar Nagenthiran criticised the TVK-led government on Sunday for the reported distribution of biscuits, instead of nutritious food, to students under the Chief Minister’s Breakfast Scheme at a school in Thoothukudi district. He referred to reports that biscuit packets were distributed to about 40 students at a primary school at Vilathikulam. “The government under [Chief Minister] Mr. Joseph Vijay could not even properly implement this welfare programme,” he said. Mr. Nagenthiran added that the government should have ascertained the number of students before planning food preparation.

CM forms 3-member committee to probe ammonia leak at seafood processing unit

It will comprise the Director of Industrial Safety and Health, Member-Secretary of the TNPCB, and Additional Director of Public Health. The panel will submit an interim report within 24 hours and a final report in 3 days. Vijay also orders inspection of hazardous industrial units across the State

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Following the death of two workers after an ammonia gas leak at a seafood processing factory at Periyapalayam in Tiruvallur district, Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Sunday has ordered the formation of a three-member inquiry committee to probe the incident.

The Director of Industrial Safety and Health, Member-Secretary of the Tamil Nadu Pollution Control Board (TNPCB), and Additional Director of Public Health will be part of the committee, and they will submit their interim report in 24 hours, with a final report set to follow in three days.

In a statement, the Chief Minister said a total of 60 women and four men who were on duty at the factory were affected due to the gas leak.

He said two women lost their lives, while the rest are being treated in the intensive care units of government and private hospitals.

He said he was shocked and saddened to learn of the tragic news and expressed condolences to the



Tragedy strikes: Minister for Artificial Intelligence, Information Technology, and Digital Services R. Kumar at a private hospital, where some of the victims have been admitted; at right, personnel of the National Disaster Response Force inspecting the seafood processing factory at Periyapalayam in Tiruvallur district on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

family members of the two deceased persons. He also ordered ₹2 lakh to be paid as solatium to the kin of the each victim from the Chief Minister’s Public Relief Fund.

Mr. Vijay announced that the State government would take measures to transport the bodies to their home State.

Special treatment

Further, he also instructed officials to ensure special medical treatment to affected persons and directed officials to provide compensation to those deceased and affected under the Employees’ State

Insurance (ESI) Scheme.

Mr. Vijay also instructed officials to conduct joint inspections of hazardous industries to prevent such accidents and directed the Minister for Artificial Intelligence, Information Technology, and Digital Services R. Kumar and Monitoring Officer for Tiruvallur K.P. Karthikeyan to give the best possible care to the affected in coordination with Tiruvallur Collector and the district administration.

Minister for Public Works Aadhav Arjuna, Minister for Health and Family Welfare K.G. Arunraj, and Minister for School

Education Rajmohan visited the Rajiv Gandhi Government General Hospital (RGGGH) on Sunday evening.

Dr. Arunraj said a total of 10 affected persons had been admitted to the RGGGH, while seven had been admitted to the Stanley Medical College Hospital. A total of 42 persons were being treated at two private hospitals in Tiruvallur district.

Two special teams of senior doctors from the RGGGH have been rushed to Periyapalayam, while another team of doctors from the Tiruvallur Government Hospital has also

been deployed at the site, Mr. Rajmohan said.

PM condoles deaths

Meanwhile, Prime Minister Narendra Modi expressed his condolences to the families of the victims.

In a post on X, he said: “Deeply pained to hear about the loss of lives due to a mishap in Tiruvallur district of Tamil Nadu. My condolences to those who have lost their loved ones. Praying for the speedy recovery of the injured.”

Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar, said: “My heartfelt condolences to the bereaved families who have lost their loved

ones in this unfortunate tragedy. I pray for strength and courage for them during this difficult time. I also pray for the speedy recovery of all those who are undergoing treatment and wish them a speedy recovery to good health.”

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami, BJP State unit president Nainar Nagenthiran, and AMMK founder T.T.V. Dhinakaran expressed their condolences to the victims’ kin and urged the TVK-led government to ensure the safety of people by conducting regular checks at industrial units across the State.

High Court takes up suo motu case to protect people from stray dogs in T.N., Puducherry

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court has taken up *suo motu* a public interest litigation (PIL) petition to ensure that the recent orders passed by the Supreme Court for protecting people from stray dogs are implemented strictly in Tamil Nadu and Puducherry.

Chief Justice Sushrut Arvind Dharmadhikari and Justice G. Arul Murugan will hear the case on Monday. The Chief Secretaries and the Secretaries to the Animal Husbandry, Health, and Municipal Administration Departments in Tamil Nadu and Puducherry have been arrayed as respondents.

On Friday, a three-judge Bench of the Supreme Court held that “unchecked population of dogs has become increasingly feral, and such animals have no place in areas densely populated by human beings owing to the



Cause for concern: A three-judge Supreme Court Bench holds that the unchecked population of dogs has become increasingly feral, and such animals have no place in densely populated areas.

serious threat they pose to public safety”. The Bench, comprising Justices Vikram Nath, Sandeep Mehta, and N.V. Anjaria, also wrote, “Compassion for animal life, howsoever important, cannot be interpreted in a manner that compels citizens to endure recurring threats to their own lives, safety, and bodily integrity.”

The Bench further observed, “This court cannot also remain oblivious to the harsh and deeply disturbing ground realities

emerging from various parts of the country.” The judges had taken note of a news report titled, ‘In just four months of 2026, Tamil Nadu records 2.63 lakh dog bites, 17 deaths’, published in *The Hindu* on May 6, 2026, and expressed shock over 6.25 lakh dog bite cases and 34 deaths due to dog bites having been reported in the State in 2025.

Referring to such alarming statistics from other States too, the judges attributed the reason for the problem reaching such a

high magnitude to the failure of the State governments and the Union Territories to implement the Animal Birth Control (ABC) framework effectively even two decades after its formulation in 2001.

The top court held that the stray dogs picked up from premises such as educational institutions, hospitals, sports complexes, bus stands and railway stations, for sterilisation, do not possess an infeasible or absolute right to be re-released at the same places from where they were picked up and that they should be transferred only to animal shelters.

The court also upheld the validity of a Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) issued by the Animal Welfare Board of India on November 27, 2025, expanding the definition of the term, ‘institutional premises’, to public spaces, such as religious places, parks, tourist sites, and recreational areas. The Bench

further underscored the need for establishing a sufficient number of ABC centres in every district across the country, appointment of enough number of veterinarians and other trained staff, conduct of regular sterilisation and vaccination programmes, removal of stray dogs from institutional premises, creation of helpline numbers to report dog bites, a mechanism for adoption of stray dogs, and so on.

Since it would be difficult for the top court to monitor the implementation of its orders at a pan-India level, it requested the High Courts to take up *suo motu* PIL petitions. The High Courts were given liberty “to expand or tailor the scope of such directions, as may be necessary to address local conditions and exigencies, without in any manner diluting the tenor and intent of the directions” issued by the Supreme Court.

Two NEET aspirants end their lives in Dharmapuri and Krishnagiri districts

The Hindu Bureau
SALEM

Two NEET aspirants ended their lives in Dharmapuri and Krishnagiri districts on Saturday evening.

Police identified the deceased as R. Roshini, 19, of Endapatti near Palacode in Dharmapuri district and C. Vetri Anandan, 20, of Bagalur Road near Hosur in Krishnagiri district.

Roshini completed Class XII in 2025 and joined a NEET coaching centre in Namakkal. For the past two months, she had been preparing for the exam at her house. Roshini had been allotted an exam centre in Dharmapuri for the re-test held on Sunday.

Around 5.30 p.m. on Saturday, her father, Ramakrishnan, 47, came home and found that Roshini had taken her own life. The Palacode police sent the body to the Dharmapuri Medical

College and Hospital for a post-mortem. The police have registered a case, and are continuing their investigation.

Vetri Anandan completed Class XII in 2023 and joined a NEET coaching centre in Namakkal, where he studied for two years.

Third NEET attempt

However, Vetri Anandan was unable to clear the exam in his previous two attempts. He stayed at home in the past year to prepare for the exam. He appeared for the test for the third time on May 3. Police sources said Anandan claimed that he would clear the exam because he found it easy. But he was upset that the exam was cancelled, and he prepared for it again.

Around 2.30 p.m. on Saturday, his mother, Uthirakumari, went to a grocery shop, and upon returning

home, she found that her son had ended his life. The Hudco police rushed to the scene and sent the body to the Government Hospital at Hosur for a post-mortem.

Note recovered

Police said they recovered a note written by Vetri Anandan, which said he was unable to bear the mental agony caused by the exam, and no one was responsible for his extreme step.

Both incidents have raised an alarm over the mental health challenges faced by students in high-stakes examinations. Investigations are under way in both cases.

(Assistance for overcoming suicidal thoughts is available on the State’s health helpline 104, TeleMANAS 14416, and Sneha’s suicide prevention helpline 044-24640050).

Kishan Reddy urges T.N. govt. to back critical mineral projects

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Union Minister for Coal and Mines G. Kishan Reddy on Sunday appealed to the Tamil Nadu government and the people for support to land acquisition for projects to mine critical minerals.

He was answering a question at a press conference in Chennai on the issues in the land acquisition for projects of NLC India Limited in Cuddalore district. “I made the request to the previous [DMK] government, too, and the new [TVK] government. With regard to the land acquisition policy, especially



Union Minister G. Kishan Reddy addressing the media at Kamalalayam in Chennai on Sunday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

for mining of critical minerals, I hope they extend their cooperation. I am also requesting the people of Tamil Nadu to extend their support to land acquisition,” he said. The Union Minister stressed that the revenue from the mining of

critical minerals would go to the State government, including the premium, royalty, DMF [funds under the District Mineral Foundation], and the cess.

Plans for NLC

Replying to a question on the possible expansion of the NLC projects, Mr. Reddy said it was a regular process.

Asked about Congress MP Vishnu Prasad’s charges of irregularities at the NLC, he said, “I have taken inputs from the local administration, the Collector, and our own agencies. Even if there is a small [issue], it is being rectified. It is a continuous process.”

HC permits Tirunelveli woman to terminate pregnancy

The Hindu Bureau
MADURAI

The Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court has underscored that the law does not compel motherhood and equally, it does not deny a competent adult woman the freedom to decide whether she wishes to continue a pregnancy.

“The Constitution places trust in the informed choice of the woman and recognises her autonomy as an indispensable component of dignity. The court is duty-bound to protect that choice,” the court said while permitting a 23-year-old woman from Tirunelveli district to terminate her pregnancy. The court was hearing the petition

filed by a man from Tirunelveli district, who sought a direction to the police not to harass him and compel him to lead a matrimonial life with the woman. Subsequently, the woman filed a petition seeking permission to terminate her pregnancy. The woman disclosed she had conceived during her relationship with the petitioner. The medical reports revealed she was approximately fifteen weeks pregnant.

Justice L. Victoria Gowri said the petition before the court presented a distressing narrative arising out of a failed personal relationship between two young adults.

The court said the woman had expressed her un-



The law does not deny an adult woman the freedom to decide whether she wishes to continue the pregnancy, says the court.

willingness to continue with the pregnancy. “The petitioner had consistently maintained his unwillingness to marry her or establish a family unit with her. In such circumstances, compelling the woman to continue an unwanted pregnancy despite her informed decision would

amount to a direct intrusion into her bodily autonomy and decisional freedom.”

The judge said “the constitutional guarantee under Article 21 of the Constitution does not permit such an outcome. The court is therefore satisfied that the request made by the woman deserves acceptance.”

Taking into account that the woman was medically stable and medical termination can be undertaken safely in accordance with accepted medical protocols, the court directed the Dean, Tirunelveli Government Medical College Hospital, to undertake medical termination of pregnancy in accordance with the provisions of the Medical

Termination of Pregnancy Act, 1971. The court also issued a further set of directions with regard to the treatment.

Taking into account that the investigation in the case was in progress, The court directed the Dean to ensure appropriate foetal tissue and other such biological samples were carefully preserved. The court also issued a set of directions in the case to the investigating officer. The court made it clear it has not expressed any opinion whatsoever regarding the paternity of the foetus or the merits of the criminal case and all issues should be decided independently by the competent court on the basis of evidence and in accordance with law.

INBRIEF



Permanent yoga centres will be set up in A.P., says Naidu

Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu on Sunday asserted that Andhra Pradesh's transformation into a "healthy, wealthy, and happy" State was possible through yoga. Mr. Naidu was speaking at the State-level events organised as part of International Day of Yoga. Yoga guru Baba Ramdev guided the session. Mr. Naidu expressed his resolve to create permanent yoga centres in the Swarna Grama and Ward Secretariats and appoint officials to supervise yoga programmes.

Kerala Assembly to discuss Revised Budget from today

The general discussion on Kerala's Revised Budget 2026-27 presented by Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan on June 19 will begin in the State Legislative Assembly on Monday. The House is likely to see heated debate on the Budget over the next three days as the Opposition Left Democratic Front (LDF) and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) have already criticised it for being flooded with announcements but lacking adequate allocations.

A.P. govt. forms SIT to probe 'custodial death' of youth

The Andhra Pradesh government on Sunday issued orders constituting a Special Investigation Team (SIT) to inquire into the alleged custodial death of Gade Sai Krishna reported in the NTR Police Commissionerate limits. Based on the complaint lodged by Sai Krishna's mother against Krishnalanka Circle Inspector S.S.V.V. Nagaraju, the SIT was constituted to ensure an impartial and transparent investigation. Inspector-General of Police M. Ravi Prakash will lead the SIT.

BJP, Congress engage in a war of 'letters' in Telangana

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

A political row broke out between the ruling Congress and the BJP in Telangana, after BJP State president N. Ramchander Rao wrote to Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy seeking an appointment with Congress leader Rahul Gandhi to discuss the implementation of the Congress party's six guarantees. Mr. Ramchander Rao's letter came in response to a recent communication by the Chief Minister to Union Minister G. Kishan Reddy, requesting him to facilitate meetings with other Union Ministers to secure approvals and clearances for key Telangana development projects, including the second phase of the Hyderabad Metro Rail.

Poll guarantees

In his letter, Mr. Ramchander Rao suggested that just as the Chief Minister had sought assistance from a BJP leader for appointments with Union Ministers, the Congress government should also arrange a meeting with Rahul Gandhi to review the status of the six guarantees promised to the people of Telangana before the Assembly elections. The remarks triggered a sharp response from Telangana Pradesh Congress Committee president Mahesh Kumar Goud, who accused the BJP of attempting to divert the attention from its own unfulfilled promises at the national level. He also questioned the BJP over issues such as the promise to bring back black money and the commitment to create two crore jobs annually.

No internal conspiracy over RS nomination: Cong. leader

Telangana AICC in-charge Meenakshi Natarajan alleges that BJP's unfair tactics led to rejection of her Rajya Sabha nomination; accuses poll body officials of compromising democratic process

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Senior Congress leader Meenakshi Natarajan on Sunday dismissed rumours that a conspiracy within the Congress led to the rejection of her Rajya Sabha nomination in Madhya Pradesh, asserting that no party leader had any reason to work against her. The BJP began spreading these rumours a day before the nomination was rejected, she alleged at a press conference here.

Responding to speculation that a Telangana Congress leader might resign to facilitate her entry into the Rajya Sabha, the AICC Telangana in-charge de-



Clearing the air: AICC in-charge of Telangana Meenakshi Natarajan with senior party leaders at a press conference. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

nied the reports. "No one is resigning for me. These reports are completely baseless," Ms. Natarajan said, adding that her political work would continue in Madhya Pradesh. She alleged that the BJP resorted to unfair tactics in

the rejection of her Rajya Sabha nomination and accused election authorities of compromising the democratic process. She said the BJP, despite lacking the numbers to win a third seat, fielded a candidate as part of a "foul

Mullaperiyar panel drops Kerala member

The Hindu Bureau
KOTTAYAM

Kerala has registered a strong protest against the Centre's decision to remove the State's representative from the Comprehensive Dam Safety Evaluation Committee, constituted to inspect the Mullaperiyar dam. Water Resources Minister Mons Joseph on Sunday, said the State was not consulted before T.K. Sivarajan was removed from

the panel and replaced by a person from Uttar Pradesh as a representative of IIT-Roorkee. "The Centre should have informed Kerala before taking such a step. Instead, the decision was taken unilaterally and the State was merely informed through a letter," the Minister said. The dam issue is under the consideration of the Supreme Court and requires mutual consensus between Kerala and Tamil Nadu, Mr. Joseph added.

ED summons Veena again in CMRL case

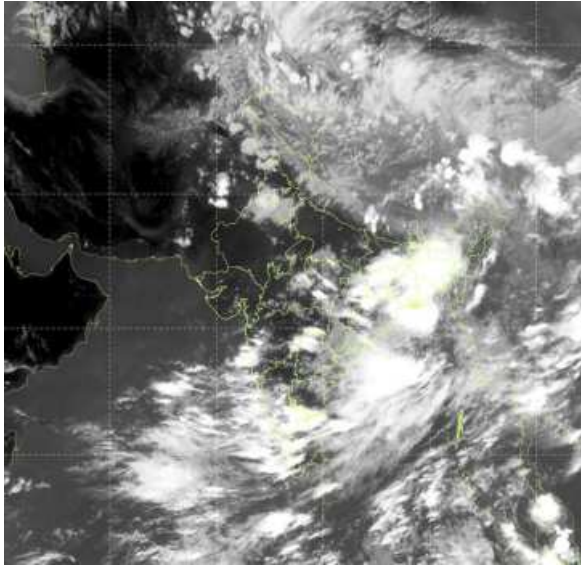
The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has issued a fresh notice to Veena T., daughter of Pinarayi Vijayan, the Leader of the Opposition in Kerala, asking her to appear before the Central agency for another round of questioning on June 29 in connection with the money-laundering probe in the Cochin Minerals and Rutile Ltd. (CMRL) pay-off case, sources said.

Ms. Veena was questioned by the ED on June 17 in connection with the case registered under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA). The ED then examined Ms. Veena's bank lockers in Thiruvananthapuram on June 19. The ED probe pertains to allegations that CMRL made payments totalling ₹2.78 crore to the now-defunct Exalogic Solutions Pvt. Ltd., owned by Ms. Veena, without receiving any services in return.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

Forecast for Monday: Heavy to very heavy rainfall very likely at isolated places over Assam, Meghalaya, Arunachal Pradesh, Sub Himalayan West Bengal and Sikkim. Dust storm very likely at isolated places over west Rajasthan. Heat wave conditions very likely at isolated places over Vidarbha.

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala		11.0		33.0		25.0	
Ahmedabad			40.7			29.0	
Aizawl			32.5			23.4	
Bengaluru		6.0		30.0		21.5	
Bhopal			35.3			25.4	
Bhubaneswar			34.6			26.2	
Chandigarh			38.9			27.6	
Chennai			33.6			27.8	
Coimbatore			33.6			24.1	
Dehradun			36.7			24.5	
Gangtok			20.7			18.2	
Goa			31.5			26.6	
Guwahati		0.6		28.9		25.5	
Hubballi			34.0			26.0	
Hyderabad		6.0		31.8		23.6	
Imphal			32.2			25.4	
Jaipur			31.0			20.0	
Kochi			30.2			26.4	
Kohima							
Kolkata			34.7			28.4	
Kozhikode			33.0			26.4	
Kurnool			36.0			27.8	
Lucknow			40.9			30.6	
Madurai			37.4			26.6	
Mangaluru		0.1		28.8		24.8	
Mumbai			34.0			25.8	
Mysuru			31.2			20.6	
New Delhi			39.2			27.5	
Patna			40.9			30.1	
Port Blair			31.2			26.3	
Prayagraj			42.5			31.0	
Puducherry			34.7			27.0	
Pune			35.6			25.1	
Raipur			40.9			29.3	
Ranchi			35.0			22.0	
Shillong			0.2			17.1	
Shimla			26.6			17.0	
Srinagar			27.4			13.9	
Thiruvananthapuram			3.0			26.0	
Tiruchirappalli			36.7			26.6	
Vijayawada		0.1		34.3		28.5	
Visakhapatnam			53.0			30.6	

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing	Yesterday
CITIES	IN
Ahmedabad	
Bengaluru	
Chennai	
Delhi	
Hyderabad	
Kolkata	
Lucknow	
Mumbai	
Pune	
Visakhapatnam	

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)
SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.
NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.
CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.
PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

Karnataka SIR: concerns rise over validity of residential certificates issued by State

Rishita Khanna
BENGALURU

With door-to-door visits scheduled to start across Karnataka from June 30 as part of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), the State government has directed Panchayat Development Officers (PDOs) to issue residential certificates to those who require them as supporting documents for the exercise. However, the Election Commission's guidelines do not accept a residential certificate. The list of 11 approved documents specifically calls for a permanent residence certificate (PRC) issued by the "competent"

State authority. Moreover, while the government has directed PDOs to issue residential certificates, as they are the authorities who usually issue such certificates, a permanent residence certificate can be issued only by a tahsildar, the competent authority for the same. **Answers sought** Against this backdrop, civil society groups such as 'My Vote, My Right,' have questioned the logic behind the government's direction. If residential certificates issued by PDOs are to be accepted during the SIR process, the government must clearly state so and ensure that they are not rejected

during enumeration or scrutiny. Citing the example of West Bengal, activist and columnist Shivasundar said that many residents submitted domicile certificates issued by the State government to establish their eligibility. These were not ordinary residence certificates but permanent residence or domicile certificates. He pointed out that the commission insisted not only on the certificate itself, but also on how it had been issued. In West Bengal, only certificates issued under the relevant government order, by specifically designated authorities, were considered valid.

Pride procession



Members of the Coalition for Sex Workers, Sexual and Gender Minorities' Rights (CSGMR), along with members and allies of the LGBTQIA+ community, take part in the Karnataka Swabhimana Habba Pride March on Sunday. SUDHAKARA JAIN

Shweta Menon-led Malayalam film body committee resigns

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The executive committee governing the Association of the Malayalam Movie Artists (AMMA), headed by actor Shweta Menon, resigned on Sunday amid internal turmoil that led to controversies and even police complaints recently. Ms. Menon also quit the association, alleging an agenda to push her panel out. The 17-member panel decided to step down after a section of the association moved a no-confidence motion against the leadership at a general body meeting held here. The lea-



Shweta Menon

dership was accused of failing to run the day-to-day affairs of the organisation and resolve the disputes within the outfit. The Shweta Menon-led committee was elected in August 2025.

Over 200 teak trees illegally axed in Chalakudy

K.S. Sudhi
KOCHI

Huge teak trees, numbering 273, were illegally sold in the territorial limits of the Chalakudy forest division, according to a preliminary investigation carried out by the Divisional Forest Officer of Flying Squad (Ernakulam). The trees were felled along an 18-km stretch from Vellikulangara junction to Vettilapala bridge. Trees on private holdings and assigned land were felled and sold cheaply, as per the report. The trees that were felled for reportedly clearing the pathway for the State hill highway were sold to a Thiruvananthapuram-based wood industries firm for ₹8.52 lakh against its assessed value



Illicit trade: Trees were felled reportedly to clear a path for a State hill highway and then sold to a private firm. REPRESENTATIVE IMAGE.

of ₹41.55 lakh, fixed by the Assistant Conservator of Forest (Social Forestry), Thrissur. The land along the road stretch was acquired by the Kerala Road Fund Board for the highway project, according to sources. The Forest Range Officer

(Pariyaram) also issued a No Objection Certificate for the firm to transport the felled trees under the provisions of the Kerala Promotion of Tree Growth in Non-Forest Areas Act 2005, according to the report. However, the Act specifies that a transport

pass shall be issued to transport only those trees which are legally felled by the owner of the holding on which they are located. The circumstances under which the officials permitted the timber firm that purchased the trees to axe and transport them should be probed, the report suggested. **Lack of documentation** No files on the holdings acquired for the road project — their survey numbers and status — and the details of the trees sold and to be axed were maintained at the Forest range office, Pariyaram, or the Social Forestry, Thrissur Division. The report also pointed out that the firm, which purchased the trees, has also started cutting trees

from the holdings. No trees located on assigned land shall be illegally cut down, sold and transported, as their ownership is vested with the State government, pointed out another report by the Additional Principal Chief Forest Conservator (Vigilance and Forest Intelligence). In the event of cutting down such trees, they shall be transported to the timber depot of the department and sold outright. The revenue generated from such sales shall be credited to the government, said the report. The report recommended initiating recovery proceedings for the lost funds and directed authorities to strictly prevent the illegal felling of trees on forest and revenue lands.



Changed reality

India must reduce its dependence on the Strait of Hormuz

Nations rise to power on the strength of their economies and, by extension, trade. Historically, countries such as the United Kingdom, Japan, the United States and China have combined economic prosperity with maritime dominance. India's weak shipping sector reflects its geopolitical position. Yet, its seafarers generate billions of dollars in foreign exchange while facing risks from piracy and geopolitical tensions. The recent conflict with Iran showed that control of strategic waterways can be as consequential as economic sanctions. By leveraging the Strait of Hormuz, Iran exposed a critical vulnerability in the global economy. Disruptions to energy flows imposed costs far beyond the battlefield and the economic consequences appear to have played a significant role in shaping the U.S. response. From a shipping perspective and its Hormuz stakes, Iran may have secured strategic gains despite the heavy damage inflicted on it by Israeli and U.S. Even as the attacks on Lebanon cast a shadow over the peace deal, Iran has announced that the Persian Gulf Strait Authority it set up during the war will be the sole authority that will handle Strait of Hormuz transits.

The memorandum of understanding envisages lifting sanctions on Iran and on ships serving Iranian trade. It also mandates Iranian talks with Oman and other Gulf states on maritime administration in the Strait of Hormuz. Previously, vessels transiting the Strait neither paid tolls nor reported to Iran or Oman. Whether or not the new framework results in transit fees is less important than the reality: that shipping companies must now account for Iran as a decisive stakeholder in the Strait of Hormuz. For India, the conflict has exposed a major strategic weakness. Despite the Strait of Hormuz being vital to its energy security, the disruption exposed the absence of a credible contingency plan for such eventualities. India's LPG strategy relies heavily on imports moving through the Strait of Hormuz, supported by a limited fleet of Indian-flagged carriers and a tightly scheduled supply chain with little long-term cavern storage. Similar vulnerabilities affected other fuel supplies too. Many countries are now reassessing their dependence on the Strait of Hormuz. The United Arab Emirates is pursuing a "zero Hormuz dependency" strategy by strengthening alternative infrastructure and routes. India must draw lessons from the crisis. Diversifying supply chains, investing in alternative maritime and land corridors, and strengthening strategic partnerships should become priorities. Projects such as Chabahar offered precisely such an opportunity but India gave up on it. For India, reducing dependence on the Strait of Hormuz is no longer just an economic goal; it is a strategic necessity.

Just truths

DNA test for paternity, allowed as a last resort, must not violate other rights

To protect children from the stigma of illegitimacy, the erstwhile Indian Evidence Act 1872 and the Bharatiya Sakshya Adhinyam 2023 place the burden of proof on the party denying paternity rather than the party seeking confirmation. The Supreme Court of India first considered the challenges posed by DNA evidence in this regard, in *Goutam Kundu* (1993), where it held that DNA tests could not be ordered as a matter of routine and that courts must first assess whether a strong *prima facie* case had been made out. It reiterated this position in *Shri Banarsi Dass* (2005); both cases also reinforced the protection of legitimacy over any interest in forensic curiosity. Then, in the litigation mooted by Rohit Shekhar alleging that veteran politician N.D. Tiwari was his father, the Delhi High Court and the top court called for the test despite Mr. Tiwari insisting that his right to privacy was being violated. In *Nandlal Wasudeo Badwaik* (2014), the Court said that when reliable scientific proof confronts legal fiction, the former may prevail in the interest of justice; in *Dipanjwita Roy* (2014), it acknowledged that refusing testing can lead to adverse inference. Both orders also confirmed the legitimacy of DNA tests based on need.

Then, in *K.S. Puttaswamy* (2017), as it encoded the right to privacy – including of genetic data – as a fundamental right under Article 21, the Court introduced a constraint that prior paternity jurisprudence did not have to reckon with. The three-fold test it set up, of legality, legitimate aims, and proportionality, was brought to bear in *Aparna Ajinkya Firodia* (2023), which concluded that DNA tests should be ordered only where they are necessary and proportionate, and not if a dispute could be resolved based on other evidence. In *Ivan Rathinam* (2025), the Court said neither privacy nor knowledge were absolute and that the judiciary also has to negotiate stigma and necessity. Its order in *CP vs AP* (2026) tied all these contentions together as it upheld a trial court's direction for a DNA test on the grounds that the disputed question of paternity could not be resolved by the existing material record and required a scientific determination, by applying necessity and proportionality considerations. In the post-*Puttaswamy* era, then, the Constitution protects bodily autonomy and restricts compelled genetic disclosure – but courts could order a DNA test if paternity is directly in issue, there is no other evidence on record capable of resolving the question, and the test would serve the interest of justice. Thus, by positioning DNA testing as a last resort, the courts have to ensure that while science may be infallible, the pursuit of truth is only just when it respects a person's rights.

Despite the Government of India's plans to amend advertising laws to curb the promotion of HFSS (high in fat, sugar and sodium) foods, such products continue to be advertised rampantly. As evidence of the health harms associated with industrially processed foods engineered to be highly palatable and potentially addictive continues to grow, restricting their advertising – particularly exposure to children and young people – may no longer be avoidable.

Try opening a YouTube video on politics, scrolling through Instagram reels, or scanning a newspaper, and you are likely to encounter advertisements for noodles, chips, biscuits, breakfast cereals, chocolates, sweetened beverages, or other ultra-processed food (UPF) products. Recently, there was a YouTube advertisement for a newly launched baked chips brand in India. The advertisement emphasised the product's cheese and tomato flavours and the "crunchiness" to appeal to consumers. What it did not disclose was that the product is a UPF with ingredients such as maltodextrin, nature-identical flavourings, flavouring substances, salt substitute (KCl/potassium chloride), acidity regulators (627, 631) and emulsifier (322). While prominently promoting selective attributes such as "baked", the advertisement omitted material health information, including the product's high salt and fat content and the presence of refined carbohydrates. Such marketing practices can create a misleading impression of healthfulness while obscuring the nutritional risks associated with these products.

While readers can recall their own experiences, there are a few other examples in the media. A female film celebrity is seen recommending a multigrain, "no maida choco cereal" for her son, despite it being a high sugar product. An entire family of actors promotes a "12-grain" breakfast cereal, while a popular film actor endorses a biscuit as a "good choice". Most of these products, however, are high in sugar, fat and/or salt, raising questions about the messages conveyed through such endorsements. Such selective disclosures create a false perception of healthfulness and deprives consumers, particularly children and adolescents, of the right to make an informed choice.

Review frameworks

The focus of this article is also to draw the attention of policymakers to the need for reviewing whether existing legal frameworks sufficiently serve the public interest. Clearer legal provisions may be required to effectively regulate the advertising of unhealthy food products.

Advertising is directly linked to increased consumption of UPFs, which is strongly associated with rising rates of obesity and diabetes. These advertisements often feature



Arun Gupta

Paediatrician, convenor of Nutrition Advocacy in Public Interest (NAPI) and co-author of the Lancet Series

Restricting the advertising of ultra-processed food (UPF) products and foods high in fat, sugar and sodium (HFSS) is a public health imperative

child actors and use emotionally appealing messages aimed at both children and parents, creating a desire for such products. The fact that in 2024, three major transnational corporations spent \$13.2 billion on advertising underscores the volumes and the power of food product advertisements. Advertising does not merely reflect demand; it helps create it. In India alone, more than two lakh junk food advertisements in a month were backed by advertising expenditure of about ₹170 crore.

Evidence suggests that UPFs can encourage overconsumption through mechanisms that resemble those identified in addiction science. The health harms associated with UPFs appear closely linked to their industrial design and marketing strategies. But the food industry fails to disclose this fact to people. Recently, the City of San Francisco filed a lawsuit against 10 major UPF manufacturers, alleging child-targeted marketing, the development of highly compelling product formulations, and inadequate disclosure of health risks such as obesity and diabetes. Among other remedies, the lawsuit sought to prevent further deceptive marketing practices and pushed for corrective measures to address the effects of past false advertising.

A policy gap

The Government of India's National Multisectoral Action Plan (NMAP) for Prevention and Control of Common Non-Communicable Diseases (2017-2022) envisaged the prohibition/restrictions on the advertising of HFSS foods. Many pre-packaged foods are highly processed, containing additives such as colours, flavours, emulsifiers and sweeteners, and are often HFSS. The issue has gained policy attention. In February 2026, the Supreme Court of India, in response to a PIL on warning labels for packaged foods, observed that front-of-pack labelling is necessary to protect the right to health. The Economic Survey 2025-26 also highlighted concerns around unhealthy diets. Several Members of Parliament have called for stronger measures, including front-of-pack warning labels, advertising restrictions and taxation of UPFs. In 2024, the Court had noted that misleading advertisements can encourage the consumption of unhealthy foods by children, pregnant women and the elderly, with potentially serious health consequences. These developments point to a growing recognition that existing safeguards may be inadequate.

The *Lancet* Series on UPFs and Human Health, published three papers in November 2025 which presented scientific evidence linking UPF consumption to poorer diet quality, displacement of real foods, and a higher risk of obesity, hypertension, cardiovascular disease, type 2 diabetes and other non-communicable diseases. Global and Indian data show that rising UPF consumption has coincided with increasing

obesity rates. *The Lancet* made a strong case for policies in the food environments to reduce UPF consumption, with many experts arguing that policymaking should not wait for further evidence.

The food environment needs a fix

Children and adolescents in India are exposed daily to advertisements for UPFs and HFSS foods on television, digital platforms, social media, sports broadcasts and through influencers. This sustained and sophisticated marketing is designed to build brand loyalty and shape lifelong consumption patterns. The aim of the UPF industry is clear: to encourage the displacement of real culinary or cultural foods for profits. What children or youth eat cannot be separated from what they are persuaded to desire at schools, work places, cinema halls, other public places or even at home.

Experts in *The Lancet* Series contend that nutrition education and behaviour-change programmes alone cannot succeed in an environment that is saturated with aggressive marketing of unhealthy food products.

This situation underscores an important constitutional principle: when harm is foreseeable and populations are vulnerable, the state has a duty to protect public health and regulate the marketing of unhealthy food products. India committed in 2017 to restrict such advertising, but that objective remains unfulfilled. Given the scale of the problem, neither market forces nor self-regulation are likely to be sufficient. Therefore, there is a strong case for the Government of India to introduce stricter controls on the advertising and promotion of UPFs and HFSS foods such as planned in 2017 by amending advertisement laws.

If schools are to be protected spaces free from UPFs, HFSS foods and misleading nutrition messages, it is inconsistent to ignore the commercial environment that shapes children's choices outside school. The school environment itself requires clear policy direction, not merely advisories (as Brazil did recently). The Economic Survey has called for stronger regulation of UPF advertising and marketing. International experience, from Chile to Mexico, suggests that voluntary self-regulation is often ineffective, whereas enforceable legal measures can be more effective. Given its influence on children's food choices, advertising warrants stronger regulation as part of the broader right to health.

Restricting the advertising of unhealthy food products need not be viewed as anti-industry or anti-profit. In fact it could reduce company expenditure on advertising and encourage companies to redirect resources towards minimally processed foods and healthier local markets. Such a shift could help shape more sustainable and health-oriented food systems in the future.

Britain after Brexit, divided, uncertain and stagnant

Some anniversaries are merely observed. Ten years after the United Kingdom voted to leave the European Union (EU), on June 23, 2016, and as it prepares for yet another change of Prime Minister, it is clear that whatever the benefits or drawbacks of Britain's divorce from the EU, Brexit has left it bitterly divided. 'Take Back Control' the Leave campaign had urged. Instead, Britain is floundering in a morass of indecision, low economic growth and a crisis of politics and governability that will likely produce a seventh Prime Minister in the decade since it voted by the narrowest of margins (52 to 48%) to separate itself from its continent and largest trading partner.

An imperial illusion

Brexit was always a trade-off in a quest by some to acquire more control over trade, regulation and immigration, tinged undoubtedly by nostalgia for Britain's imperial past. The idea that Britain could successfully swap access to the €18 trillion European economy for trade deals based on the ties of Empire – and thrive – was always for the birds, but nostalgia is powerful and illogical. Brexit began as a civil war within the Conservative Party amongst those resisting the EU's project of 'ever closer union' and railing against a perceived overbearing and over-reaching Commission that set rules for others to follow. The rules, however, were the conditions under which Britain gained access to the trading partner that, even after Brexit, accounts for 41% of its exports and 50% of its imports.

When David Cameron offered the U.K. an 'in/out referendum' to settle the war within his party, Brexit morphed into a protest vote. It stopped being about Britain's relationship with Europe and transformed into Westminster's relationship with the rest of the country, especially those parts that felt left behind. Brexit unearthed a raft of problems that had little to do with the EU's rules (which London helped shape



Priyanjali Malik

Writes on security and politics

Ten years after Brexit, Britain still searches for direction

as a member state), or the free movement of people (a precondition of the single market), even if the 2004 expansion brought a surge of Eastern Europeans settling in Britain for work. Britain's problems were structural. After the 2008 financial crisis, the standard of living for the vast majority stagnated or declined, hit by the years of austerity subsequently imposed on the country to balance its books. While the bankers and banks who precipitated the crisis came through unscathed, life became tougher for ordinary people left to contend with the increasingly underfunded public services they relied on – health care, education and local government.

The resentment this bred provided fertile ground for populism to thrive, and Brexit's focus on immigration provided just that. Immigrants, the siren song went, were taking their jobs, occupying their schools, clogging up their National Health Service (NHS) and pushing them to the margins in their own country: once Britain controlled its borders, life would improve.

Economic reality bites

Things have not improved. While estimates of Brexit's economic costs vary, most economists agree that the loss of unfettered access to Britain's largest trading partner and the end of free movement have acted as a drag on trade and investment, curtailed productivity, and significantly diminished the market for financial and other services. The beneficiaries of Brexit are largely those who facilitate the now voluminous customs paperwork and the additional civil service hires managing Brexit's complexity. And, ironically, those immigrating to Britain are from outside the EU.

For all the rhetoric about controlling immigration, this decade has seen a sharp rise in immigration, largely from outside the EU. Though the number of EU nationals residing in Britain declined gradually from 2016, the number of non-EU immigrants rose sharply from just under 100,000 to peak in 2022-23 at over a million

before falling to about 400,000 now. After COVID 19, the NHS, unable to find qualified workers at home, recruited aggressively from abroad. With Europeans feeling unwelcome, doctors and nurses from India, Nigeria, Egypt, Pakistan and the Philippines came instead. Before Brexit, there were 10,000 nurses from India. Today, there are 40,000. Ironically, visibly non-white people were flocking to Britain and the immigration statistics continued to rise while the cost of living was battered by Brexit, COVID-19 and geopolitics.

An uneasy nation

The topic of immigration has become toxic. Hijacked by the far Right, it now represents all the broken promises of the social contract. Because Brexit split the country down the middle into solidifying tribal loyalties of Leavers and Remainers, no matter the unfulfilled promises of leaving, politicians across the spectrum remain afraid of honestly evaluating Brexit. Worse, electorally threatened by the populists (not known for their honesty) mainstream politicians across the political spectrum have focused on the bogeyman of immigration in search of populist votes. A former Home Secretary (of Indian extraction) spoke of the 'invasion of our southern shores' while in office. Out of office, her colleague publicly counted white faces in a Birmingham neighbourhood. And the current Prime Minister voiced concern about Britain becoming an 'island of strangers'. These are not words to unite a multicultural country, forge a middle ground and seek honest answers for Britain's economic problems. Ten years on, Britain is deeply divided about who it is and what it stands for. The centre ground lies vacant as politicians chase populist extremes, making politics a game of survival. The statistics speak for themselves: since Brexit, the U.K. has seen 10 Home Secretaries, nine Foreign Secretaries, eight Chancellors of the Exchequer and six Prime Ministers, with a seventh likely incoming. This is not a country at ease with itself or its place in the world.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Israel must show restraint

Because of Israel's belligerent actions, efforts to secure a lasting truce in the war with Iran have once again become elusive, and the Strait of Hormuz faces renewed disruption (Page 1, June 21). While the U.S. and Iran have agreed to a ceasefire, Israel continues to

undermine prospects for lasting peace. It is time for U.S. President Donald Trump to rein in Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and insist on adherence to the agreement. Unless Israel withdraws from southern Lebanon and ceases repeated violations of the

ceasefire, the hope of a durable truce will remain elusive. **Prabhu Raj R.,** Bengaluru

Ensure Census accuracy

The decadal Census is the bedrock of India's policy planning. However, recent field observations in my

locality raise concerns about the integrity of the data collection process. I witnessed enumerators gathering residents from multiple households in a common area, rather than visiting individual units, and bypassing upper floors of residential buildings. While the hardships faced by our

enumerators such as extreme heat and the immense physical labour of climbing floors are undeniable, such shortcuts risk creating systemic data gaps. An undercount in even a single neighbourhood leads to a decade of misallocated resources. I urge the

authorities to implement a more transparent monitoring system where citizens can verify whether their specific household has been officially surveyed.

Kota Venkata Yogesh, Proddatur, Andhra Pradesh

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

The lack of accountability within the NTA

On June 21, more than 22.8 lakh candidates sat once again for NEET-UG after a paper leak led to the nationwide cancellation of the earlier exam. The response has followed two tracks. The first was prosecutorial, with the government handing the case to the Central Bureau of Investigation under the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024. The second was administrative, with a re-examination conducted yesterday and the examination fees refunded. However, neither response engages with the question of why one compromised paper can interrupt medical admissions for an entire national cohort, and what that design choice reveals about how the state looks at the costs of its own institutional failures.

The NTA's responsibility
The National Testing Agency (NTA) was created in 2017 as a registered society under the Societies Registration Act, 1860 and not through an Act of Parliament, which means it operates without a codified liability standard toward the candidates it examines. When the NTA cancelled NEET-UG 2026, its formal obligation to candidates extended to just carrying forward registrations and refunding the examination fee, which is ₹1,700 for general category candidates. The institutional cost of failure beyond that narrow zone remains unaccounted for.

The design of NEET-UG amplifies that accountability gap directly. The examination is conducted nationwide in a single sitting on one day, with one paper and its score is used for admission across every government and private medical college in the country. And when that sitting is compromised, the state has only one instrument available, which is to cancel the test and convene a fresh sitting without any distributed fallback that would allow a limited breach to produce only a limited effect. Moreover,



Rahul Verma
Sociologist and independent researcher who writes on education, labour and social inequality in India

While the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024 prescribes penalties and fines, it establishes no compensation mechanism for candidates when an exam is cancelled

the interval between application, examination, and result has become a prolonged administrative cycle and every disruption stretches that cycle further while shifting uncertainty onto the candidates. In a system built around a single annual test, even a short advancement can alter an entire admission year.

The National Medical Commission's (NMC) seat matrix for October 2025 lists roughly 1.26 lakh MBBS seats against more than 22 lakh candidates, a ratio that structurally ensures that a substantial cohort of aspirants are always in their second or third attempt, having already committed resources with no guarantee of admission. For those candidates, the cancellation returns a ₹1,700 fee against a preparation year that costs several lakhs in coaching and accommodation, a gap the state has never formally measured because no government survey tracks what households spend on NEET preparation. The ASER 2024 report documents persistent learning gaps between government and private school students, which means candidates who entered the race with fewer academic and financial resources are also those least able to absorb a cancelled cycle and begin again.

While the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024 prescribes penalties of up to 10 years imprisonment and fines up to one crore rupees for organised leak networks, it establishes no compensation mechanism for candidates when an exam is cancelled; creates no automatic re-examination right; and introduces no liability standard for the examining body. The legislature responded to a candidate-facing catastrophe with an entirely prosecutorial instrument, leaving the structural consequences borne by those who played by the rules entirely outside the law's concern.

The announced shift of NEET to Computer-Based Testing (CBT) does not resolve this structural

problem. For in June 2024, the UGC-NET was cancelled after the question paper appeared on the darknet; the UGC-NET was already a CBT examination administered by the same agency. The leak arose not from printed papers but from a single session with no distributed architecture capable of containing the impact of a breach, which means that moving NEET to CBT changes only the delivery mechanism without changing the single point of failure.

The way ahead
Article 14 guarantees everyone equal protection before the law and prohibits state action that is arbitrary in design and disproportionate in effect, while Articles 41 and 46 of the Directive Principles place a positive obligation on the state to secure equal opportunity in education and protect weaker sections from structural disadvantage. A national entrance architecture that formally treats all candidates alike but transfers all costs of institutional failure onto those least equipped to bear them is precisely the kind of design those provisions are meant to prevent.

Three corrections must follow directly. First, the NTA should be given statutory basis with codified obligations to candidates and enforceable consequences for institutional failure. Second, a mandatory compensation mechanism funded from examination fee revenue should activate automatically when cancellation results from institutional failure. Third, multiple examination windows per year would distribute risk so that a compromised sitting does not collapse the prospects of every candidate in the pool.

The re-examination has, for now, closed this episode administratively, leaving the structural consequences borne by those who played by the rules entirely outside the law's concern. The problem is not only who leaked the paper, but why the exam was designed to break so completely when they did.

Kerala's battle with water-borne diseases

The State's under-investment in proper sewerage networks is costing it dearly

STATE OF PLAY

C. Maya

A State renowned for being the model of public health in the country and one which has consistently recorded some of the best health indicators nationwide, is now battling recurrent outbreaks of various water-borne diseases such as shigellosis. The irony is stark, for Kerala has demonstrated the responsiveness and resilience of its health system by having a firm grip on a disease as unpredictable and complex as Nipah.

Now, rapid urbanisation and social development on the one side and inadequate attention paid to environmental health, water quality measures, poor sewage and sanitation infrastructure on the other, is threatening to undo the State's reputation as a beacon of good public health. The explosion of water-borne diseases and zoonotic diseases in the State points to the system's failure to pay attention to the social and environmental determinants of health.

Scale of contamination
A look at the outbreaks of Acute Diarrhoeal Diseases (ADD), Hepatitis A, shigellosis and norovirus in recent years gives an indication of the impact of groundwater contamination on people's health.

Between four to five lakh cases of ADD are reported every year in the State. Since the past two decades, Kerala has also been experiencing several large and small Hepatitis A outbreaks. In 2025, the State reported 31,536 cases and 82 deaths due to Hep A. This year too, as of June 15, close to 9,000 cases and 25 confirmed deaths have been reported.



Amoebic meningoencephalitis, which has also emerged as a significant public health problem in Kerala, is being linked to the faecal contamination in domestic wells, in which free-living amoeba thrive. This infection has claimed the highest number of lives in the State, with 134 cases and 34 deaths reported as of June 15 this year.

Various studies have reported that groundwater resources in the State have been under increasing stress, with 62% of the population depending on ground water from close to 7 million wells.

Lack of sewage system
As of 2025, Kerala has less than 6% proper sewerage network coverage, with most major cities having virtually no household sewage collection systems. The CAG's 2025 report stated that at the closure of the AMRUT Mission, a Central initiative aimed at ensuring universal access to safe water and reliable sewerage connections across urban areas, Kerala's overall achievement was just 11.25% and only 0.13% households got sewerage connections.

While Kerala does have high sanitation coverage with a significant proportion of households relying on septic tanks or on-site sanitation systems, these septic tanks are poorly designed and located close to domestic wells which lead to groundwater contami-

nation. The fact that Kerala is one of the most densely populated States with small landholdings and houses situated close to each other aggravates the issue. High levels of faecal contamination have been reported in over 70% of the open wells in the State by agencies such as the Centre for Water Resources Development and Management. A study in the urban areas of Thiruvananthapuram in 2018 had reported that coliform contamination was prevalent in 73% of wells and that well chlorination and cleaning practices were inadequate.

Recurring outbreaks of Hepatitis A and shigellosis in the State showed that almost all outbreaks had been in rural areas and were linked to the local source of drinking water. Epidemiological investigations have revealed that water for regional supply systems is often pumped into supply lines without adequate chlorination or filtration, and that these lines often run close to sewage drains – any breaks in the pipeline can lead to major contamination.

It is also true that most of the interventions to provide safe drinking water to people lie outside the health sector, demanding coordinated intersectoral efforts. Thus, rather than a failure of public health, the current problem of water-borne diseases seems to be the result of the State's under-investment in establishing proper sewerage networks.

Prevention of water-borne diseases requires long-term investments in urban planning, establishing safe water distribution systems, sewer networks, wastewater treatment plants as well as measures for environmental and water quality surveillance.

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The curious case of Kerala's committed expenditure

Despite grave concerns raised in the white paper, Kerala's budget was silent on measures to bring down the committed expenditure

DATA POINT

Devvyanshi Bihani

The white paper, 'Kerala's Fiscal Health – A Status Report', released by the new United Democratic Front (UDF) government ahead of its maiden budget, raised serious concerns over the State's rising debt burden. The report in particular underscored the huge share of the State's "committed expenditure" – which includes salaries, pensions and interest payments.

It emphasised that nearly 78% share of committed expenditure in the total revenue receipts left little to no room for capital expenditure and contributed to mounting revenue deficits. Kerala's spending on salaries and pensions, as a share of its revenue receipts, is the highest among all States and its share of committed expenditure the second-highest (**Chart 1**). The trend has more or less remained the same over the years (**Chart 2**).

Noting that the State spends "almost 80%" of its revenue on committed expenditure, the white paper said, "The most direct structural explanation for Kerala's treasury stress is the share of its revenue that is pre-empted before any discretionary decision." "Now is the time for hard political decisions," it said, adding that measures such as increasing the retirement age and making pay commission revisions decennial should be considered.

Yet, the budget was conspicuously silent on any such measures, barring the exception that the National Pension System would be revamped. The silence is perhaps an acknowledgement of not just the difficulty in tackling this "structural problem," but the importance of high spending on salaries and pensions in achieving the progress the State has made on human development indicators.

Economist R. Ramakumar said retaining the idea of a welfare state

requires welfare workers and pointed out that Kerala employs significantly more teachers, healthcare professionals and other public-sector workers (**Chart 4**). "Kerala's achievements are due to this particular kind of salaries that you end up paying," he added. Moreover, he said that while the figure of over 75% highlighted prominently in the white paper has "shock value", a better parameter would be the committed expenditure's share in the total revenue expenditure and not revenue receipts, which would bring the share down to about 58-60%.

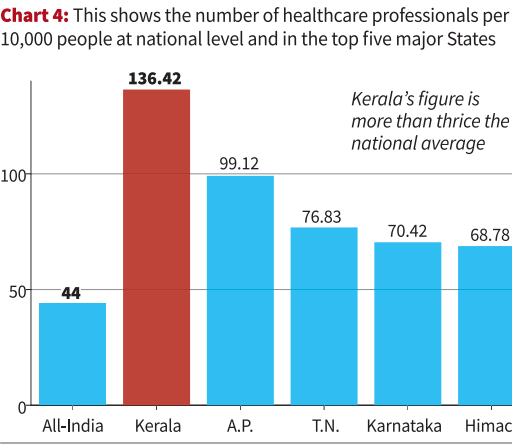
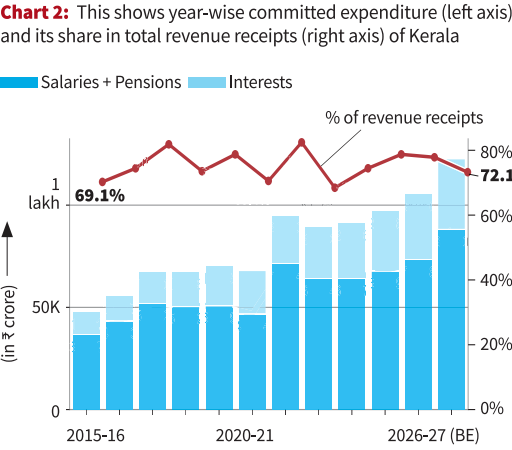
Economist Lekha Chakraborty, meanwhile, said the trend reflected public expenditure rigidity. "All that we can do is an episodic expenditure (sectoral) compression, given the committed nature of spending. While the state has shown revenue buoyancy, without meaningful public expenditure reforms, this pattern risks perpetuating revenue deficits and constraining Kerala's ability to sustain its social model," she said.

Kerala's State's Own Tax Revenue (SOTR) and overall revenue receipts have shown notable growth, but the tax buoyancy has dropped in recent years. Moreover, their respective Compound Annual Growth Rates (CAGRs) between 2015-16 and 2026-27 (budget estimates) show that the committed expenditure has grown faster (**Chart 3**). The budget, presented on Thursday, estimates the debt-to-GSDP ratio to come down marginally to 33.5% in 2026-27, compared with 34.87% (2024-25) or 34.26% (2025-26), even though it projects the total outstanding debt to rise by 11.6% (**Chart 5**).

These optimistic projections show that the new government is relying on a swift turnaround in tax buoyancy and GSDP growth – it estimates the GSDP to grow nominally by 14.15% and revenue receipts by 23.8% – while recognising that expenditure on salaries and pensions cannot be brought down, at least in the near future.



Challenges ahead: Kerala CM V.D. Satheesan presented the revised budget for 2026-2027 on Thursday, amid concerns over growing debt.



Structural hurdles

Data were sourced from Kerala's Revised Budget 2026-27, Kerala's Fiscal Health: A Status Report, the Reserve Bank of India, the CAG and Central Bureau of Health Intelligence

Chart 1: This shows the share of committed expenditure in the revenue receipts of each State. The data shown is for the year 2024-25, taken from RBI

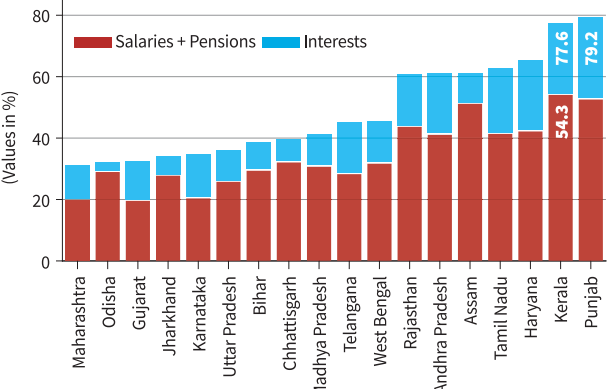


Chart 3: This shows the growth in overall revenue (●), State's Own Tax Revenue (SOTR) (●), and the committed expenditure (●), along with their respective CAGR between 2015-16 and 2026-27

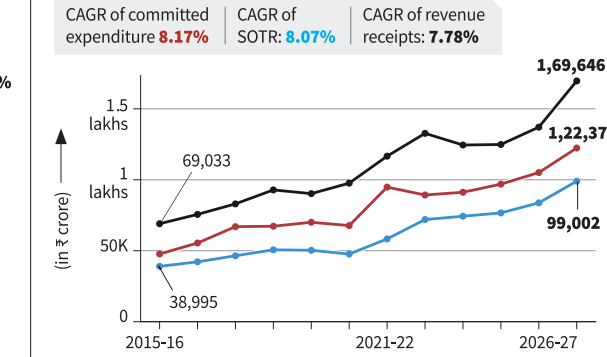
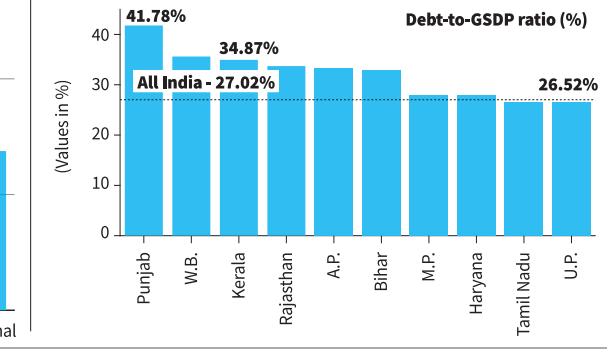


Chart 5: The debt-to-GSDP ratio of select States for 2024-25. Kerala has estimated its debt-to-GSDP ratio to come down to 33.5% despite the debt expected to grow by 11.6% to ₹ 5.46 lakh crore



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu

FIFTY YEARS AGO JUNE 22, 1976

Incentive to boost handloom exports

Madras, June 21: Export of handloom goods formed about 50 per cent of the country's total exports during 1975-76 and it was expected to be exceeded this year, in spite of the difficulties the industry faced, Mr. Mani Narayanaswami, Development Commissioner for Handlooms, said here to-day.

A coded system of classification and fixing standards for the export varieties by voluntary organisations would be useful, he added.

Inaugurating the annual meeting of the Handloom Trade and Industry Association here, Mr. Narayanaswami said the Government was having continuous dialogue with all interests concerned for the development of the industry and a co-ordinated effort was necessary to improve the economic condition of weavers.

He wanted big exporters to adopt certain areas and help the weavers so that they could see a definite transformation in their standard of living. The intention of the Government was to modernise handloom sector.

To encourage exports the Government had decided to make available cash incentives for a whole year from April this year.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO JUNE 22, 1926

Madras news agency

Mr. Sami Venkatachalam Chetti, the President of the Madras Corporation, performed last evening the pleasant function of opening the Mount Road Branch of the Madras News Agency. Mr. S. Srinivasa Iyengar presided on the occasion. There was a fair gathering. Mr. R. Balasundaram Mudaliar, the Editor of 'Doodle' uncle of Mr. T. Thanikachalam, the Proprietor of the Agency, received guests on arrival. The branch is situated in one of the rooms of the groundfloor of the Mahajana Sabha.

Mr. S. Srinivasa Iyengar in requesting Mr. Sami Venkatachalam Chetti to open the new branch, said that no public man could afford to ignore the Press in these days and the Press depended most on distribution.

The Madras News Agency, he understood, had been doing good work in the direction of distributing newspapers and magazines for the last four years. There lay great scope for these agencies in India and he wished prosperity for this undertaking.

MVA boycotts customary tea party held by government

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

The Opposition Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) alliance boycotted the Maharashtra government’s customary tea party organised on the eve of the legislative session to protest against the “failed administration of the State government”.

The MVA criticised the government for not providing satisfactory answers on many issues, including drought, farmers’ issues, rise in atrocities against women, drug trafficking, and the deteriorating law and order in the State.

The government should make farmers’ 7/12 extracts (*saat baara utara* land records) debt-free instead of trapping them in technicalities, the MVA leaders said.

The government’s farm loan waiver is fraudulent and farmers have been trapped in terms and conditions, the MVA leaders alleged. Congress leaders in the State accused the BJP-led government of corruption, alleging that contractors had to pay large commissions to get bills for work. Funds allocated for the Jal Jeevan Mission, and many development works, were revised downwards, the Opposition said.

With 2 more MPs, Shinde says ‘Operation Tiger’ wins

Six of the nine MPs from the Shiv Sena (UBT) have signed a letter forming a separate group, and have also met Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla; Ashtikar, Omraje Nimbalkar latest to switch sides

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI

Operation Tiger is successful, Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde announced on Sunday, adding he had never left any operation incomplete. Two of the six Lok Sabha members of the Shiv Sena (UBT) on Sunday announced that they were slated to join Mr. Shinde.

Nagesh Patil Ashtikar, Shiv Sena (UBT) MP from Hingoli, and Omraje Nimbalkar, the party MP from Dharashiv, cited lack of development funds as one of the primary reasons for taking the decision.

Mr. Ashtikar blamed the Shiv Sena (UBT) leaders for speaking ill against them, claiming that they took the decision only after Uddhav Thackeray’s party leaders spoke in a derogatory manner against them. “Till June 18, we had not taken any decision,” he said in a video statement.

Meanwhile, top sources in the Shiv Sena confirmed to *The Hindu* that all the six MPs of the Shiv Sena (UBT) had already signed a letter



Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis and Deputy CMs Eknath Shinde and Sunetra Pawar in Mumbai on Sunday. PTI

forming a separate group, and had also met Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla. They are slated to merge with the Shiv Sena, a senior leader said. “There were quite a few obstacles at the last minute. But we have successfully overcome them. We had support from the central BJP leadership,” a leader told *The Hindu*.

When Mr. Shinde was asked about the developments on Sunday evening, he said, “Those who know me, know that we do not leave any operation incomplete.” It referred to the defection of six of the nine MPs of Shiv Sena (UBT).

The two-third majority would save them from disqualification proceedings, Sena leaders said. At least three of these six MPs are slated to hold rallies in their own constituencies on Monday.

“Operation Tiger is successful. The body is healthy,” Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis added, while interjecting Mr. Shinde on Sunday.

Uddhav slams BJP
Amid the developments of Operation Tiger, Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Uddhav Thackeray hit out at the BJP on Sunday, during his

public rally in Mumbai North East. “Though the Shiv Sena fought against the Congress for so many decades, the Congress never tried to break away our party. It is the BJP’s sin,” he said.

The six MPs who are slated to break away from the Shiv Sena (UBT) are – Sanjay Dina Patil, Sanjay Jadhav, Sanjay Deshmukh, Bhausaheb Wakchaure, Mr. Ashtikar, and Mr. Nimbalkar.

On Sunday, Mr. Nimbalkar held a closed door meeting with his party cadre in his home constituency. Thereafter, he announced his decision publicly. “We will go in the Shiv Sena Shinde group and we will work under the leadership of Eknath Shinde. I have not taken this decision for any position or for money. I have also discussed with my people. So far, I have only received the love and blessings of the Shiv Sena chief. And irrespective of whatever is being said against us by anybody, we will not speak a word against *Matoshree* (residence of the Thackerays),” he said.

Trinamool’s minority cell head quits, joins the rebels ‘for the sake of people’

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

Mosaraf Hossain, president of the Trinamool Congress’s minority cell, joined the Ritabrata Banerjee-led rebel group in the West Bengal Assembly on Sunday.

Mr. Hossain, the MLA for Itahar in Uttar Dinajpur district, told presspersons that he had submitted his resignation letter to Mamata Banerjee citing family issues.

“My mother is not well. I just returned from Mecca after Haj. I can’t even attend the Assembly sessions regularly due to her health condition. I need to be with her all the time. It is not possible for me to attend the Assembly session regularly. In such a situation, I have decided to resign,” Mr. Hossain said.

The leader said he was in regular touch with Mr. Banerjee, the Leader of the Opposition in the Assembly. After he rebelled, Mr. Banerjee was expelled from the Trinamool. He has claimed the backing of 65 rebel MLAs.

“Since the government has changed, it has not been possible to work like I

Mosaraf Hossain submitted his resignation letter to Mamata Banerjee citing family issues

used to do earlier. I have extended my support to Ritabrata for the sake of the people of my constituency and their development,” Mr. Hossain said.

Warm ties with CM
Praising Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari, Mr. Hossain said, “Our current Chief Minister had once served as an observer in Uttar Dinajpur during his stint with our party. I developed a wonderful relationship with him since then. My only target is the development of my area. I want to take part in all his development works in the future.”

In a recent rejig in the Trinamool party organisation on June 5, Mr. Hossain was retained as the president of the minority cell. The restructuring was carried out two days after 59 Trinamool legislators joined a rebellion and backed Mr. Banerjee as the new Leader of the Opposi-

tion instead of Sobhandeb Chattopadhyaya in the Assembly. Mr. Banerjee and another MLA, Sandipan Saha, had alleged that their signatures were forged in the letter sent nominating Mr. Chattopadhyay as the Opposition leader.

Mr. Hossain was first fielded from Itahar by the Trinamool in the 2021 Assembly election by dropping the two-time MLA, Amal Acharya. He retained the seat in 2026.

His resignation comes amid the Assembly session, which started on Friday.

Since the BJP government came to power in the State, 59 Trinamool legislators and 20 MPs have openly rebelled against the party and some have accused Trinamool national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee of mishandling the party. Three Rajya Sabha members – Sukhendu Sekhar Roy, Sushmita Dev and Prakash Chik Barik – resigned from their parliamentary posts and organisational roles. Days after being appointed adviser to the party’s national working committee, former Minister Jyotipriya Mallick quit on Friday.

Voting should be recognised as a fundamental right, says Ramesh

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The right to vote should be recognised as a fundamental right to ensure the highest level of judicial review and protection, along with safeguards against voter suppression or arbitrary exclusions during exercises such as the special intensive revision (SIR), senior Congress leader Jairam Ramesh said on Sunday.

Mr. Ramesh made the remarks in the context of the recent Supreme Court judgment declaring the right to walk on a footpath a fundamental right. Providing historical context on the evolution of fundamental rights and electoral provisions, he argued that while the top court has already in the past recognised voters’ right to know candidates’ criminal re-



Jairam Ramesh

cords, funding sources, and has protected ballot secrecy and enabled NOTA, but voting itself continues to remain a statutory right. “All related rights are fundamental, but not the core right they depend on,” he said.

He said elevating the right to vote has become essential in the present context. “With the blatant-

ly partisan functioning of the Election Commission of India working at the behest of the Prime Minister and the Union Home Minister having been brutally exposed, it is now time to elevate the right to vote as a fundamental right that would offer it the highest level of judicial review and protection,” he said.

“It would be a powerful step in putting in place safeguards against voter suppressions or arbitrary disqualifications that have taken place in different states in astronomical numbers under the SIR process. It would also mean greater Supreme Court vigilance over the functioning of the Election Commission,” he added.

Referring to the Constituent Assembly debates, Mr. Ramesh said an Advisory Committee on Funda-

mental Rights, Minorities and Tribal and Excluded Areas was set up under Sardar Patel. At its meeting on April 21-22, 1947, there was discussion on making the right to vote a fundamental right. Dr. B.R. Ambedkar and Babu Jagjivan Ram supported the proposal, he said, while Sardar Patel, C. Rajagopalachari and others opposed it.

“Sardar Patel himself took the position that universal adult franchise was, in itself, an implicit fundamental right. This is the background to Article 326 which provides for elections based on universal adult suffrage,” he said.

He also cited Justice Ajay Rastogi’s dissenting opinion in the *Anoop Baranwal vs. Union of India* judgment of March 2023, which held that the right to vote is a fundamental right.

BJP is set to script history in Punjab in upcoming polls, says Nitin Nabin

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

BJP president Nitin Nabin on Sunday said that Punjab was ready for change as its people were looking up to the BJP with “high hope and expectations”. The State goes to the polls in 2027.

“Punjab not only protects India’s borders but also safeguards the soul of India. Bringing Punjab out of the present crisis and making it secure, prosperous, and strong is the core agenda of the BJP. The BJP is set to script history in Punjab,” he said at events in Jalandhar and Ludhiana.

“Punjab is the land of the Gurus’ teachings, the penance of saints, and the blood of martyrs. It represents a living tradition of service, dedication and sacrifice,” he said.



BJP president Nitin Nabin performs yoga on the occasion of the International Day of Yoga at Phagwara in Punjab on Sunday. ANI

“Every grain of Punjab’s soil reminds us that a nation is not sustained merely by power; it is shaped by the values imparted by saints, and the soul of India resides in them. The rulers may change, but the soul of India has never changed. Whenever society has gone astray, saints have shown the right path.

Whenever darkness increased, saints lit the lamp of hope, and whenever divisions arose in society, saints worked to unite people,” he said.

Drug menace
Mr. Nabin, who is on a three-day visit to Punjab, said the State was grappling with the menace of

drugs and there was a need for a unified crusade against drug abuse.

“Drug addiction has become a curse for the people of Punjab. We must reject it outright. It is destroying lives and devastating countless households. On this International Yoga Day, let us collectively pledge to eradicate this scourge from Punjab and the entire nation. We will not tolerate anything that weakens our roots or allows this poison to enter our society,” he said.

“India is now marching forward with a singular national objective. The mantra of *‘Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas, Sabka Prayas’* remains the driving force guiding the country towards becoming a developed nation by 2047,” he added.

Rahul’s resistance plank needs viable pathway to power

NEWS ANALYSIS

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), which recently completed 12 consecutive years in office at the Centre, has often ridiculed the “multiple re-launches” of Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha.

To underscore its claim that Mr. Gandhi is not a serious political challenger, the BJP has frequently deployed a battery of spokespersons and Ministers to rebut his statements, often seeking to portray him as politically inconsistent.

Against this backdrop, Mr. Gandhi’s address at the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) meeting on June 8 merits closer attention. The speech not only criticised the BJP but also framed the political contest in terms of neutrality of institutions and the need for organised resistance to the institu-

tions’ alignment with the BJP’s narrative. This approach marks an evolution in the Opposition leader’s political argument.

For years, he has accused the Narendra Modi government of undermining constitutional institutions. At the INDIA meeting, however, he advanced the proposition that Opposition parties were fighting their battle with outdated tools. Those instruments worked only when the Indian state “provided a fair field for them to operate in”, he argued.

‘No level-playing field’
“That field doesn’t exist any more,” Mr. Gandhi said. “The BJP controls the legal system. The BJP controls the bureaucracy. The BJP controls the intelligence agencies. The BJP even controls the Election Commission (EC).”

Beyond sending a message to INDIA bloc constituents, his repeated invocation of institutions serves a dual political purpose. First, it mobilises Opposition supporters by framing the contest as one



Rahul Gandhi

between constitutional values and political power. Simultaneously, it signals to officials in these institutions that their actions are being publicly scrutinised and recorded as part of a larger democratic struggle.

“The entire architecture – media, social media, the legal system, bureaucracy, intelligence agencies – is aligned to keep this government in power,” Mr. Gandhi said.

These institutions, including the EC, are thus portrayed as active participants in furthering a particular political narrative. This is where the

theme of resistance emerges as a significant trope.

“The Congress party is a party of resistance. It does not require the neutrality of the Indian state to operate. In fact, the more the institutions of the Indian state are throttled, the more aggressively the Congress party will fight to defend the Constitution,” Mr. Gandhi said.

“You don’t need the bureaucracy. You don’t need the intelligence agencies. You need the act of resistance – meaning: I will resist. I will not allow injustice. Full stop, the end. It is a spirit. It is not an organisation,” he added, invoking the Congress’s role in the freedom movement.

Whether this strategy can translate into electoral success remains an open question. Resistance can mobilise supporters around questions of democratic accountability, but political parties require a compelling alternative narrative and a robust organisation on the ground to convert sentiment into votes.

The party must also build a coalition of interests among

voters and devise effective messaging to translate dissatisfaction with the government into electoral support.

Effective messaging
Mr. Gandhi’s emphasis on social justice and backward classes is yet to yield significant electoral dividends for the Congress. His latest outreach to students and Gen Z appears to be part of a broader effort to cultivate a new political constituency.

The challenge before Mr. Gandhi, therefore, is to convert a narrative of democratic resistance into a broad-based political project capable of persuading voters that the Congress can effectively take on the BJP’s organisational and electoral dominance. If the resistance is to become more than a slogan, it must evolve into a political coalition, with a credible programme and path to power. Whether Mr. Gandhi can make that transition may well determine not only his own political future but also the trajectory of Opposition politics in India.

GOVERNMENT OF PUDUCHERRY DIRECTORATE OF INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY

NOTICE FOR EXPRESSION OF INTEREST
Eol No. 13031/DIT/2026/01 Puducherry, Dated: 22-06-2026
“EXPRESSION OF INTEREST FOR PARTNERING IN SETTING UP OF AI CENTRE OF EXCELLENCE IN PUDUCHERRY”

Offers are invited from intending corporate / academic / research organizations registered under the Companies Act 1956 / relevant statutes of the Government of India / State Governments for PARTNERING IN SETTING UP OF AI CENTRE OF EXCELLENCE IN THE UNION TERRITORY OF PUDUCHERRY. The Eol details, terms and conditions, technical and operational requirements and time schedule are part of the document. The document can be downloaded from <https://py.gov.in> (Notice Board – Tenders). The offers with the required documents may be submitted on or before 06th July 2026.

DIRECTOR
DIRECTORATE OF INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY
No: 82/DIP/AD(PRESS)/ADVT/2026-27



ODISHA CONSTRUCTION CORPORATION LIMITED
BHUBANESWAR, ODISHA,
PIN: 751012, Tel No. (0674) 2562020
e-Mail: theoccltd@odishaconstruction.com;
GSTIN - 21AAACO2571K22M

“e”-Procurement Notice No. 07 /OCCL/2026-27 (on-line)

Tenders are invited on EPC-Turn Key basis for the following works :

Sl No.	Name of Work	Name of Division	Bid Identification No.	Approx. Value of Work	Bid Security (through On-Line transfer/as per DTCL) (in Rs.)	Period of Completion	Availability & Submission of Tender (on-line)
01	Separate pipe line from Salia Reservoir to Intake point at INS chilika (Solopokhari pump house) to supply water throughout the year to meet 60 Lakh litres per day including O & M of the project for a period of five years.	Khurda Irrigation Division	OCCL-HQ/01/2026-27	Rs.23.00 Crore	Rs.23,00,000/-	12 (Twelve) months	From 23.06.2026, 03.30 PM to 14.07.2026, 5.30 PM.

Procurement Officer : Managing Director, OCCL.
Date of Opening of the Tender : 15.07.2026, 12.00 Noon onwards.
Further details can be seen from the e-procurement portal: <https://www.tendersodisha.gov.in>

MANAGING DIRECTOR
34001/375/2627
OIPR-34001/34120/126-27/00011

MOLUQUE

Hospital cover: pricey/costly either way

COVERNOTE

K. Nitya Kalyani

In the previous instalment of Cover Note we saw the angst over rising hospitalisation premium and revisited the idea, “Why not do away with the basic policy and keep only a top-up policy with, say, a ₹10 lakh threshold? A medical expenses fund can meet the first ₹10 lakh and further expenses can be claimed from top-up policy.”

That would work up to a point. If you can’t get a basic policy or failed to renew/lost coverage, then pick this option. If you are doing this exercise volitionally, how do you decide if it works? You have to start with some assumptions, educated guesses. What kind of hospitalisation am I likely to face in the future and maximum expense? If your answer is ‘less than ₹10 lakh,’ here are the options. If you have a basic policy, you can make a claim and if you don’t, the medical expenses fund will come in handy. If you wind up with very expensive surgeries/hospital stays, the top- up policy will also come into play after ₹10 lakh is spent via the basic policy or from your pocket. So, top up is for catastrophic claims.

The math

The idea is sensible in principle. Look at the math. If you pay ₹50,000 for a ₹10 lakh cover, in 10 years you would have paid half the sum insured as premium. You can be peeved if no claim is made. Of course, over 10 years, the premium would have doubled so you may have paid more than half the sum insured! So, saving this as a medical fund is a reasonable idea but whether it works depends on age, medical status and whether you will keep the money for intended use.

The wins

Let us see the pros of the idea. We already saw we save on the bigger premium for the basic cover and pay only the smaller premium for the top up.

Plus, you don’t have to deal with claims for the first ₹10 lakh, saving quite some effort, paperwork and tension. No waiting for pre-authorisation, wondering if your claim will be paid in full, hesitating to spend on a higher rent room and stressing about cashless approval or chasing reimbursement claims.

So, if you can set aside ₹10 lakh and for good measure, add the notional premium you would have otherwise paid each year, wisely invest it, make it grow and keep it intact till its time of use. The ability to do depends on economic status, liquid assets, stable income and whether or not about ₹10 lakh hospital bill worries you.

The fund option is more efficient economically than insuring the first tranche of risk. Large companies use this strategy of retaining small losses and insuring only catastrophic ones, thus saving on premium.

The flip side

Guessing the type/size of claims isn’t easy. What if, instead of the rare ₹25 lakh expense, you repeatedly incur ₹5-₹10 lakh across many years. The base policy renews the ₹10 lakh cover every year and pays out. Your fund is a standalone protection and will run out after two/three such occurrences.

And then, there can be cancer or kidney disease with expenses recurring over many years, repeated hospitalisations and ICU care.

Not only surgery or hospital stay, diagnostics and medication are costlier too. Add to this loss of wages or employment due to illness, and the situation would be unbearable for a medium income family.

So, strategies must differ depending on financial resilience and assessment of healthcare needs. There is more and we will see them in the upcoming instalment of Cover Note.

(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history.)

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.



ILLUSTRATION-SAAI

Basis of your investment decisions, product choice

You have to cut through the hype and understand how the product is suitable so as to achieve your desired financial goal within the investment horizon set by you

THE RIGHT ONE

Joydeep Sen

The basis of portfolio allocation decision is financial goals, risk tolerance, investment horizon, etc. Here, we will scratch the surface on the multiple investment products crying for attention.

Underlying for product

Any investment product invests in the underlying market. Conventionally, underlying markets are equity stocks, bonds, and gold. There are also new concepts such as real estate where you can invest via Real Estate Investment Trusts (REITs) and infrastructure via Infrastructure Investment Trusts (InvITs). Potentially, there could be other investment assets like commodities (other than gold or silver), but these are yet to emerge as popular ones via investment vehicles. For HNIs, there are things like art but these are not available in the retail space.

The staple investment base is equity stocks and bonds, also known as fixed income or debt. Equity represents part ownership of the firm whose stock you are buying. As the firm grows, and new investors come in, the value improves and price increases. This leads to returns from investments in equity. Bonds represent ‘I owe you’ or loans given by the investor to the issuing entity. There is a defined inter-



At bottom of pyramid are bank term deposits where there is a defined rate of interest and maturity and the rate is not market dependent

est payable on a defined date and maturity of bond or debenture is defined as well. The typical aspect is equity has given relatively higher returns than debt but has been relatively more volatile as prices fluctuate more. Gold is known as a ‘portfolio diversifier,’ with some allocation to gold, the volatility-adjusted return of a portfolio is better.

At the bottom of the pyramid, there are bank term deposits where there is a defined rate of interest and maturity. The interest rate is not dependent on any market condition. Bank FDs are not transferable. At the higher end of the pyramid, there are derivatives where the base is equity/government bonds/commodities, which are more risky.

Investment vehicles

You can invest directly. You can buy equity stocks from the exchange via stock broker. These days there are multiple apps where you can do KYC online and start buying/selling stocks. For buying bonds online, there is Reserve Bank of India’s platform called Direct Gilt, where you can buy government instruments. For



Every investment product will have an investment objective, portfolio disclosure and track record unless it is a newly launched product.

buying corporate bonds, there are Online Bond Provider platforms (OBPPs). You can invest in gold via Exchange Traded Funds (ETFs) or Electronic Gold Receipts (EGRs).

However, to manage a fund of equities and/or bonds, you need a professional. Therein comes the concept of investment vehicle: a fund management entity which will run a fund and will charge a fee.

The most popular investment vehicle is a mutual fund (MF), where you can buy units of a professionally-managed fund and liquidity is high. There are portfolio management services (PMS) with a minimum ticket size of ₹50 lakh and alternative investment funds (AIF) with a minimum ticket of ₹1 crore. Insurers offer Unit Linked Insurance Plans (ULIPs).

Choosing a product

The investment vehicles mentioned earlier, known as product manufacturers, offer a plethora of products, which are a combination of the base mentioned earlier with packaging.

You have to look at:

1. The risk in the underlying base: equity is more

volatile than debt; within equity small cap or sectoral/thematic funds are relatively more volatile. In debt, higher rated bonds carry less credit risk.

2. Required investment horizon: historic performance of any asset i.e. equity or debt, gives an idea how volatile it has been, hence how long you should be in the product at the minimum.
- Every investment product will have an investment objective, portfolio disclosure and track record unless it is a newly launched product. There is a concept called drawdown, which shows in the worst phase of performance, what was the return from that product. You need a horizon longer than the drawdown and recovery phase.
3. Liquidity: you may need cash flow at any time for an eventuality. You need to be aware upfront on product liquidity. Some products are not liquid by definition e.g. RBI Floating Rate Bonds. Equity is liquid but it is a function of the market level at that point of time. If the market is correcting you may redeem the fund subject to exit load but you would be taking home less.

While liquidity is desirable, it is not compulsory everything in portfolio should be liquid. There would be a certain liquid component, say 10% and a major ‘saleable’ or ‘if required’ component.

(Joydeep Sen is a corporate trainer (financial markets) and author)

Does age determine asset allocation?

THINKINVESTOR

For goal-based investments (the core portfolio), asset allocation is a function of the required return (called the minimum acceptable return) to achieve the goal and not your age

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Asset allocation is a vital step in the portfolio construction process. We have said you need three variables to determine asset allocation viz. time horizon for the goal, the amount needed to achieve the goal (terminal wealth) and the amount you can save monthly to get there. Let’s now address whether your asset allocation is also a function of your age.

Risk factor

Many consider age as a crucial factor in investment decision making. The argument is we tend to become less risky or more conservative as we age. That risk appetite gradually reduces as we age is mostly true. But should age be a factor to fix asset allocation?

To understand this, consider two individuals, one aged 30 and the other 45, both want to buy a house 10 years hence. The asset allocation for them is a function of the same three variables-time horizon for goal, terminal wealth and monthly savings earmarked for the goal. So, age does not directly impact asset allocation process. It could indirectly feed into your asset allocation process via aspirations. The individual who is younger may be risk seeking and aspire for a larger house, and therefore need larger terminal wealth. Or the individual may decide to save less for the same terminal wealth as the other. A larger terminal wealth for the same amount of savings or a lower savings amount for the same terminal wealth will both need higher allocation to equity.

Conclusion

The reason most consider age as an important factor in asset allocation process is a popular thumb rule based on it, which is 100 minus age. Based on this rule, two individuals, both aged 30, should have 70% allocation to equity. Unfortunately, the argument does not consider income volatility of the individuals. What if one individual has a stable income and the other has a large proportion of the income that is variable pay? Or what if one individual has stable employment and the other works in a cyclical industry in the private sector?

Also, the thumb rule does not consider that an investment earmarked to achieve a life goal has a finite time horizon. For goal-based investments (core portfolio), asset allocation is a function of the required return (called the minimum acceptable return) to achieve the goal, not your age.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Personal Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 year	Loan amount 1 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
HDFC Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to Rs 6,500
Tata Capital	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Flat Rs. 99
State Bank of India	10.00-15.00	10,624-11,895	2,125-2,379	Up to 1.50% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
ICICI Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 2%
Bank of Baroda *	10.15-18.00	10,660-12,697	2,132-2,539	Up to 2% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Axis Bank	8.95 onwards	10,367 onwards	2,073 onwards	Up to 2%
Kotak Mahindra Bank	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 5%
Bank of India	10.85-16.15	10,834-12,199	2,167-2,440	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 250; Max. Rs 15,000)
Canara Bank	9.70-15.15	10,550-11,934	2,110-2,387	0.25% (Rs 500 - Rs 2,500)
Punjab National Bank	10.25-16.80	10,685-12,373	2,137-2,475	Up to 1%
HSBC Bank	9.75 onwards	10,562 onwards	2,112 onwards	Up to 2%
Federal Bank	11.75 - 18.99	11,059 - 12,968	2,212 - 2,594	Up to 3%
Union Bank of India	8.90 - 12.65	10,355-11,287	2,071-2,257	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 7,500)
Bajaj Finserv	10.00-30.00	10,624-16,177	2,125-3,235	Up to 3.93%
Punjab & Sind Bank	9.60-13.85	10,525-11,595	2,105-2,319	0.50%-1%
Indian Overseas Bank	10.25 onwards	10,685 onwards	2,137 onwards	Up to 0.75%
UCO Bank	9.95 - 13.20	10,611-11,428	2,122-2,286	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 750)
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 3.5%
Bank of Maharashtra	9.75-15.00	10,562-11,895	2,112-2,379	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Central Bank of India	11.25 onwards	10,934 onwards	2,187 onwards	Up to 1%
IndusInd Bank	10.49 onwards	10,744 onwards	2,149 onwards	Up to 3.5% (2% for instant personal loans for limited period)

*Interest concession of 0.10% to customers opting for group credit life insurance.

Car Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Union Bank of India	7.50-10.00	10,019 - 10,684	Up to Rs 1,000
Punjab National Bank	7.60-10.70	10,043 - 10,797	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 1,500)
Bank of Baroda	7.60 - 11.35	10,043 - 10,959	Up to Rs. 2,000
Canara Bank	7.45-11.45	10,007 - 10,984	50% waiver on [0.25% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)]
Bank of India	7.60-12.55	10,043 - 11,262	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 10,000)
UCO Bank	7.35-10.00	9,983 - 10,624	0.5% (Max. Rs 5,000)
State Bank of India	8.80 - 9.85	10,331 - 10,587	Rs 750 - Rs 1,500
IDBI Bank	7.75-9.30	10,078 - 10,452	Rs 2,500
Bank of Maharashtra*	7.45-11.75	10,007 - 11,059	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Indian Overseas Bank	7.55-12.00	10,031 - 11,122	NIL
ICICI Bank	8.40 onwards	10,234 onwards	Up to 2%
HDFC Bank	8.15 onwards	10,174 onwards	Up to 0.5% (Rs. 3,500 - Rs. 8,000)
Karnataka Bank	8.12-11.62	10,167 - 11,026	Up to 0.60% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 11,000)
Punjab and Sind Bank**	7.50-14.00	10,019 - 11,634	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Indian Bank	7.50-9.65	10,019 - 10,513	Rs. 1,200
IDFC FIRST Bank	8.99 onwards	10,377 onwards	Up to Rs. 10,000
Central Bank of India	7.60-9.30	10,043 - 10,452	0.50%(Rs. 2,000 - Rs. 20,000)

*0.25% concession for home loan borrowers/other customers having at least 6 months of relationship with bank
**Concession of up to 50% on processing fee for PSB Apna Vahan Sugam.

Rates and charges as on June 17

Source: Paisabazaar.com

Taiwan to hold five days of combat readiness drills: Defence Ministry



Ukraine's battlefield shift has not solved its humanitarian crisis: IRC



Man charged over suspected anti-Muslim attacks in Edinburgh



Wife of detained ex-Sri Lankan spy chief alleges harassment by officials



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Champions are often defined by their response to setbacks. **Praggnanandhaa** answered an early stumble with a remarkable run that culminated in a historic Norway Chess title.

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STRAIGHT FACED

Curacao 'keeper Room jokes he deserves statue after heroics



REUTERS

Curacao goalkeeper Eloy Room joked that he deserves a statue on the Caribbean island after a jaw-dropping display. His tally of 15 saves is the most on record — since 1966 — by any goalkeeper in a World Cup match that did not feature extra-time. “I’m really proud of the team also... I think I need a statue in Curacao, I think now.”

LANDMARK GAME

Smooth Japan strolls to victory over scratchy Tunisia



REUTERS

Japan marked the 1,000th game in World Cup history with a 4-0 thrashing of Tunisia in Monterrey on Saturday. Ayase Ueda scored twice while Daichi Kamada and Junya Ito were also on target as the Asian giants joined the Netherlands on four points at the top of Group F. Tunisia can no longer get a place in the knockout rounds.

CULTURAL CHANGE

Bielsa feels hydration breaks have altered the very nature of football



REUTERS

Uruguay coach Marcelo Bielsa has criticised the hydration breaks introduced at the FIFA World Cup. “Playing four times instead of two alters the conception of what had been culturally built to interpret football. I will just say that before this decision, football had a characteristic; now it has another”.

RACE AGAINST TIME

Brazil's Raphinha to have 'intensive treatment' on thigh injury



AP

Brazil forward Raphinha will undergo “intensive treatment” after suffering a muscle injury to his right thigh in its World Cup win over Haiti, the Brazilian football confederation said on Saturday. Brazilian website *Globo Esporte* reported he could be fit to return for a possible game in the last 16, which starts in two weeks.

Spain finds its scoring boots again as it slams four past Saudi Arabia

The former champion puts behind the horrors of failing to break the deadlock against Cape Verde in the first round with a masterclass in control as it runs the Asian side ragged; Oyarzabal bags a brace and also sets up Yamal's opener

FIFA WORLD CUP
Avon Sengupta
ATLANTA

Spain had arrived in Atlanta needing a response. Ninety minutes later, it left with relief, having rediscovered the goals that had deserted it against Cape Verde to secure a 4-0 win over Saudi Arabia and breathe life back into its stuttering World Cup campaign. While the temperature outside hovered around 30 degrees Celsius and humidity pushed past 70%, inside the covered stadium, it was a comfortable 22 degrees, ideal conditions for Spain's preference for a quick-passing game. Luis de la Fuente's side started with far greater purpose than in its opening match. Lamine Yamal, handed a place in the starting XI, hugged the right touchline and immediately gave Spain a direct outlet to stretch the Saudi defence. Two corners arrived within the opening 10 minutes, and Spain, frustrated by its failure to score against Cape Verde, showed a willingness to shoot whenever any space opened up. The breakthrough arrived in the 11th minute as Spain moved the ball from left to right with the ease of



Easy pickings: Oyarzabal bundles the ball in from up close for Spain's third against Saudi Arabia. AP

a tide rolling across a shoreline. Mikel Oyarzabal's low cross flashed across the face of the goal, and Yamal, arriving unseen at the far post, guided home his first World Cup strike. The second goal came moments before the hydration break as Saudi Arabia dithered in clearing a corner, allowing Oyarzabal to finish from close quarters. Spain's attacks were now rolling in one after the other, with each wave more damaging than the last.

THE RESULTS
Group E: Germany 2 (Undav 68, 90+4) bt Ivory Coast 1 (Kessie 30); Ecuador 0 drew with Curacao 0. Group F: Tunisia 0 lost to Japan 4 (Kamada 4, Ueda 31, 83, Ito 69). Group H: Spain 4 (Yamal 10, Oyarzabal 21, 24, Al-Tambakti 49-og) bt Saudi Arabia 0.

Barely a minute after the restart came the third, with Oyarzabal grabbing his second after Dani Olmo had squared Marc Cucurella's header across goal, leaving the Real Sociedad forward with hardly any work left. Saudi Arabia's misfortunes continued when an unmarked Cucurella's left-footed strike cannoned into goalkeeper Mohammed Al Owais and then ricocheted off Hassan Al Tam-bakti to trickle over the line, draining the last remnants of Saudi resistance. Substitute Ferran Torres twice had the chance to add further gloss to the scoreline, but the Barcelona winger's finishing re-

mained as wayward as it had been in the opening game. Even his stoppage-time effort was ruled out for offside. But after it was left stranded in still waters by Cape Verde, Spain found a current in Atlanta to carry its World Cup ambitions forward. As the noisy *La Roja* faithful spilled into the humid Georgia evening, the tide had once again turned in favour of one of the tournament's early favourites.

Undav fashions Germany's back-to-the-wall victory

Agence France-Presse
TORONTO

Germany reached the World Cup knockout phase for the first time since 2014 with a dramatic come-from-behind 2-1 victory over Ivory Coast on Saturday. Substitute Deniz Undav scored twice, including the crucial goal four minutes into injury time, triggering a massive roar from the overwhelmingly pro-German crowd here. Germany had not advanced from the group stage since winning the 2014 tournament in Brazil, and coach Julian Nagelsmann had been under

Tuesday's matches	
GROUP I	
France vs. Iraq,	2.30 a.m.
Norway vs. Senegal,	5.30 a.m.
GROUP J	
Jordan vs. Algeria,	8.30 a.m.
GROUP K	
Portugal vs. Uzbekistan,	10.30 p.m.
The day and time(s) pertain to India	

huge pressure to make that breakthrough. He paid tribute to Undav's clinical finishing — and said it was “not out of the question” that he could start the next game against

Stat attack

1Sweden became the first team to win by four goals (5-1 vs. Tunisia) and then lose by four goals in successive matches in the same edition since Turkey in 1954 (beat South Korea 7-0, lost to West Germany 7-2)

1Undav is the first German (after Klose in 2002) to score in each of his first two World Cup games

3Ueda became the first Japanese player to net a brace and have three goal contributions in a World Cup contest

3m 27sKamada scored Japan's fastest goal in the global extravaganza

4Japan became the first Asian team to find the target four times in a World Cup game

5Netherlands equalled its record for most goals in a World Cup match

8The Dutch became the eighth nation to score 100 goals in the quadrennial showpiece

11Germany's longest winning streak (in all competitions) after the 12 consecutive victories between May 1979 and June 1980 (under Derwall)

12The Germans progressed to the knockout stages for the first time in 12 years

15Room recorded the most saves in a World Cup game (in regulation time) and also kept a clean sheet

16Germany extended its record for most comeback wins in World Cup history

16m 12sBrobbe netted the quickest brace from kick off in the World Cup since Podolski in 2006 (11m 35s, Germany vs. Sweden)

21Neuer became the goalkeeper with the most World Cup games, surpassing France's Lloris (20). Only Matthaus (25) and Klose (24) have played more World Cup games for Germany

29y 183dKessie became the second-oldest Ivorian scorer in the global event after Drogba in 2010 (32y 101d)

100Gakpo's second goal was the 100th scored in this edition

1000Tunisia and Japan played the 1000th match in World Cup history

UND AV

COMPILED BY ANIRUDH VELAMURI

Room shines as Curacao gets off the mark

Agence France-Presse
KANSAS CITY

Curacao goalkeeper Eloy Room was the hero against Ecuador on Saturday, keeping out a barrage of shots to help the tiny Caribbean nation claim its first ever World Cup point in a goalless draw that keeps alive its hopes of reaching the knockout phase. Ecuador, which finished second in South American qualifying, had 28 shots, including 15 on target but Room stood firm in an astonishing display. His 15 saves are the most on record, since 1966, by any goalkeeper a World Cup match that did not feature extra-time. The South American team ended the first half with 65 percent of possession but nothing to show for its dominance. The Curacao players swarmed around Room at the end of the match, celebrating an extraordinary point.

All eyes on Messi and Argentina

Avon Sengupta

Lionel Messi has spent the better part of two decades bending football's sense of time. Records that once looked permanent have become milestones in his journey through the game. Defenders have changed, managers have changed, even the shape of Argentina around him has changed, but the central question has remained stubbornly familiar — how do you stop Messi when a match begins to orbit around him? Austria will be the next team asked to find an answer to that question. After scoring the 61st hat-trick of his career, 50 for clubs and 11 for Argentina, in the 3-0 win over Algeria, Messi stands one goal away from moving past Miroslav Klose as the World Cup's all-time leading scorer. If he strikes against Austria, the eight-time Ballon d'Or winner will also become only the third player in the tournament history to net in six consecutive World Cup matches. Just Fontaine did it for



Milestone beckons: Messi needs just one more goal to become the all-time leading scorer in the World Cup. GETTY IMAGES

France in 1958 and Jairzinho followed for Brazil in 1970, both across single tournaments. Messi's run began with Argentina's win over Australia in the round of 16 during its long-awaited triumph in Qatar four years ago and continues into what is expected to be his final World Cup. Nearing 39, his influence shows little sign of fading. Against Algeria, he had a direct hand in eight of Argentina's 10 shots, taking six himself while creating two chances. Yet while

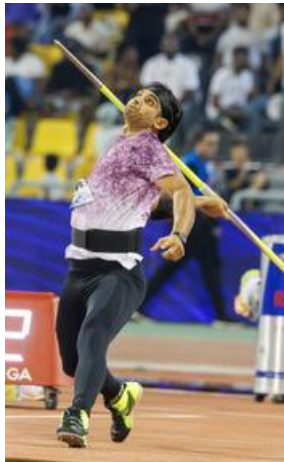
Messi stole the headlines, Argentina's defensive authority was just as important. Lionel Scaloni's midfield, led by Alexis Mac Allister and Enzo Fernandez, expertly shielded its defence and did not allow Algeria a single shot on target. Austria arrives in Dallas after a 3-1 win over Jordan and will look to extend its four-game winning run in all competitions. “We know how good Argentina are,” young midfielder Paul Wanner said. “We respect them, but we

are confident in our strengths. If we bring our qualities to the pitch, we will pose problems for any team.” Austria's pressing game will try to disrupt Argentina's rhythm, but coach Ralf Rangnick has injury concerns. Captain David Alaba, Stefan Posch, who wore a specially designed protective mask after breaking his jaw against Jordan, and Alessandro Schopf have all trained separately and are racing against time to be fit for the all-important game. Argentina, too, is worried about the fitness of defender Gonzalo Montiel, who is still recovering from a hamstring injury. If the South Americans beat Austria and Jordan fails to defeat Algeria, Scaloni's side will be guaranteed a place in the knockout rounds as the winner of Group J. For Argentina, this is another step towards the ultimate goal of another World title. For Messi, it is another opportunity to claim yet another record that once seemed untouchable.

Good performances over chasing success for Neeraj

Uthra Ganesan
NEW DELHI

A nine-month break to recover from multiple injuries forcing a late start to the season saw Neeraj Chopra finish fourth in his maiden competition, at the Doha Diamond League, this year. Coupled with his eighth-place at the 2025 World Championships, this is the longest the Olympic and World champion has gone outside the podium. A year ago, it would have been a certified disaster. Now, the 28-year-old admits it is simply a step towards regaining his form and fitness, preferring to focus on going big at major events rather than chasing success at every outing. “There was no pressure (at Doha), I just wanted to play. I wanted to do what I was doing in training and not do anything extra. I only wanted a good throw and I got that with 85.69m, which felt good because I wasn't going that far in training.



Neeraj. GETTY IMAGES

“If I had been fourth or even third earlier, I would have never accepted it. For that matter, I would have never accepted an 85m throw either. But this time I knew my situation, where I was coming from, what I was coming back from. My preparation was good and I knew we have to move forward step by step. I was happy with whatever I got,” Neeraj told *The Hindu* on the sidelines of the Indian Athletics awards. “Right now, I am work-

My preparation was good and I knew we have to move forward step by step

ing on my training. The body is feeling better now. It's not the same as it was before, I am not the old Neeraj but I am slowly coming back. It took a long time because it wasn't just one injury, there were several. I had an Achilles injury in my blocking leg, in my back, I had some issues in my shoulder and elbow. And I have been having trouble with my groin for a long time. “So after Tokyo, we decided to do rehab first, start slowly, not take any pressure and not be in a hurry to return to competition. Which is why I started throwing only in May this year, usually it starts in January itself. But such is the life of an athlete, you always carry your injuries like medals,” he laughed.

Kapp's all-round show takes South Africa past India

The veteran follows up her two-wicket haul with an unbeaten 45-ball 81 as the Proteas chase down 159 in the final over; poor fielding hurts the Women in Blue as their semifinal hopes suffer a setback

T20 WORLD CUP

P.K. Ajith Kumar
MANCHESTER

They all got starts. They all promised. None delivered. India's batters disappointed, yes. But the South Africans deserve credit. They bowled with a plan and their hearts out. And then Marizanne Kapp produced an innings she or her team will not forget anytime soon.

South Africa delivered a body blow to India in what was always going to be a crucial match in the Women's T20 World Cup. The Proteas won by six wickets with five balls to spare at Old Trafford here on Sunday.

With the red-hot Australia on top of Group A with three wins in as many games, the battle is between India and South Africa for a spot in the semifinals.

After reducing India to 158 for seven, South Africa survived a scare posed by Shree Charani, who removed the South African captain Laura Wolvaardt



Pumped up: Kapp was at her best both with the ball and bat as South Africa edged India. GETTY IMAGES

and Annerie Dercksen in a maiden over.

But Kapp stayed firm. She took her team home, remaining 81 not out (45b, 7x4, 4x6). Her third-wicket stand of 97 with Tazmin Brits (40, 36b, 2x4, 1x6) took the game away from

India. Poor fielding compounded the problems for Harmanpreet Kaur & Co.

Earlier, it was a case of South Africa getting just about everything right, and India getting most of it wrong. The bowlers were marshalled superbly by

their captain, who brought in the right bowler at the right time. And all that meant the Indian innings did not really get going despite a brisk, confident start by Smriti Mandhana and Shafali Verma.

In fact, their opening

stand (30) and 33-run partnership for the fifth wicket between Harmanpreet (24) and Deepti Sharma (29) were the two biggest of the innings.

Wolvaardt and her bowlers never allowed the Indian batters to settle.

The way Smriti and Shafali started off, it had looked as though the large number of Indian supporters – the diaspora travels from different parts of the country, wearing blue and cheering loudly and tirelessly – would get to witness the famed strokeplay of the Women in Blue.

All they got was a glimpse. In the second over, Smriti caressed the pacer Shabnim Ismail through the off-side, and then swivelled to pull the next ball for another boundary. But, in the next over, she for once looked ungainly, walking across for a scoop against Kapp and was bowled.

Kapp's expression showed how much that wicket mattered. Smriti had come into this match after making 68 and 74 in her two innings in the tournament.

Shafali, who had also been looking good, joined her senior partner in the dressing room. She backed away only to glove an express delivery from Shabnim. She began her walk back before the DRS verdict came.

This was an opportunity

SCOREBOARD



INDIA
Smriti Mandhana b Kapp 17 (12b, 3x4), Shafali Verma c Jafta b Ismail 31 (15b, 4x4, 1x6), Yastika Bhatia lbw b Khaka 15 (13b, 3x4), Jemimah Rodrigues c & b de Klerk 12 (14b, 1x4), Harmanpreet Kaur b Ismail 24 (22b, 2x4), Deepti Sharma c Kapp b Mlaba 29 (21b, 3x4), Richa Ghosh c Khaka b Kapp 15 (14b, 2x4), Arundhati Reddy (not out) 6 (7b), Prema Rawat (not out) 3 (2b); Extras (w-6); Total (for seven wkts. in 20 overs): 158.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-30 (Smriti, 2.6 overs), 2-54 (Shafali, 5.4), 3-67 (Yastika, 7.2), 4-83 (Jemimah, 10.2), 5-116 (Harmanpreet, 14.4), 6-137 (Deepti, 17.3), 7-153 (Richa, 19.2).

SOUTH AFRICA BOWLING
Kapp 4-0-27-2, Ismail 4-0-28-2, Tryon 2-0-23-0, Mlaba 4-0-33-1, Khaka 4-0-31-1, de Klerk 2-0-16-1.

SOUTH AFRICA

for the Indian middle-order to come good. But it didn't, for the third time in as many matches. And for once Richa Ghosh didn't explode.

So India had to be content with a score that seemed well within reach of South Africa. Or Kapp, on this day.

Other scores: Group B: Sri Lanka 98 in 19.4 overs (Nilakshika

Laura Wolvaardt c & b Shree Charani 20 (21b, 2x4, 1x6), Tazmin Brits c Shree Charani b Shafali 40 (36b, 2x4, 1x6), Annerie Dercksen b Shree Charani 0 (2b), Marizanne Kapp (not out) 81 (45b, 7x4, 4x6), Nadine de Klerk b Shree Charani 5 (7b, 1x4), Chloe Tryon (not out) 10 (4b, 2x4); Extras (lb-4, w-1); 5; Total (for four wkts. in 19.1 overs): 161.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-25 (Wolvaardt, 5.2), 2-25 (Dercksen, 5.4), 3-122 (Brits, 16.1), 4-137 (de Klerk, 17.5).

INDIA BOWLING

Shafali 4-0-22-1, Nandani 2.1-0-17-0, Arundhati 3-0-29-0, Shree Charani 4-1-24-3, Prema 2-0-21-0, Deepti 4-0-44-0.

Toss: India; **PoM:** Kapp. South Africa won by six wickets with five balls to spare.

India's next match: June 25 vs. Bangladesh, Manchester, 7 p.m. IST.

Silva 30, Hayley Matthews 3/15, Karishma Ramharack 2/15) lost to West Indies 99/5 in 16.1 overs (Kavisha Dilhari 2/22).

Toss: West Indies; **PoM:** Matthews.

On Saturday: Group B: England 200/5 in 20 overs (Sophia Dunkley 57, Alice Capsey 40, Freya Kemp 39 n.o., Dani Gibson 30 n.o., Kirstie Gordon 2/30) bt Scotland 162/7 in 20 overs (Sarah Bryce 34, Sophie Ecclestone 2/23).

Toss: Scotland; **PoM:** Dunkley.

Kohli's participation depends on fitness clearance; no spot for Jaiswal

Sports Bureau
BENGALURU

Virat Kohli has been named in India's ODI squad for the three-match series against England in July, but his availability is subject to fitness clearance.

Kohli injured his hamstring in the IPL final late last month and subsequently missed the home series against Afghanistan. Yashasvi Jaiswal, who took Kohli's place and even scored a century in Chennai on Saturday, is not in the touring party.

Kohli's fellow ODI-only specialist Rohit Sharma, whose middling form had recently given rise to a few murmurs, will look to build on his two promising knocks of 48 and 79 against Afghanistan. Star pacer Jasprit Bumrah is back in the roster, and so is left-arm



Hard done by? Jaiswal found no place in the touring party after Kohli was picked in the squad. FILE PHOTO: K.R. DEEPAK

spinner Axar Patel. Speedster Prince Yadav and left-arm twaker Harsh Dubey have made way.

Gurnoor Brar, who took seven wickets across three fixtures against Afghanistan, has retained his place while the fit-again Harshit Rana will travel too.

Meanwhile, Varun Chakravarthy has been excised from the squad for the two T20Is in Ireland later this month as he is still recovering from the foot injury he sustained during the IPL. The 34-year-old will now aim to be fit for the five-match T20I series versus

England that commences on July 1.

ODI squad for England: Shubman Gill (Capt.), Shreyas Iyer (Vice-capt.), Rohit Sharma, Virat Kohli (subject to fitness clearance), K.L. Rahul (wk), Ishan Kishan (wk), Washington Sundar, Axar Patel, Nitish Kumar, Kuldeep Yadav, Jasprit Bumrah, Prasidh Krishna, Harshit Rana, Arshdeep Singh and Gurnoor Brar.

The schedule: First ODI: July 14, Birmingham (3.30 p.m.); Second: July 16, Cardiff (5.30 p.m.); Third: July 19, Lord's, London (3.30 p.m.).

Updated squad for Ireland T20Is: Shreyas Iyer (Capt.), Tilak Varma (Vice-capt.), Abhishek Sharma, Sanju Samson (wk), Ishan Kishan (wk), Shivam Dube, Nitish Kumar, Axar Patel, Washington Sundar, Ravi Bishnoi, Harshit Rana, Arshdeep Singh, Prince Yadav, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi and Prasidh Krishna.

The dates: First T20I: June 26, Belfast (6 p.m.); Second: June 28, Belfast (6 p.m.). All timings are in IST.



Henry... a lethal spell. AFP

Henry gets the job done as the Kiwis level series

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Matt Henry took four wickets for no runs in just 12 balls as New Zealand thrashed England by 253 runs in the second Test at the Oval on Sunday for a series-levelling win.

New Zealand only needed 48 minutes on the fifth day to complete a crushing victory as England was bowled out for 209, with Henry's six-wicket haul in the second innings giving him match figures of 11 for 109.

Stokes back
Ben Stokes will return as England captain for the third Test in Nottingham, head coach Brendon McCullum announced.

The scores: New Zealand 391 & 362 bt England 291 & 209 in 58.1 overs (Root 77, Brook 58; Henry 6/29). **PoM:** Henry.

Harshit and Akshat do a 1-2 for India

ASIAN GYMNASTICS

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Indian gymnasts Harshit Damodaran and Akshat Bajaj secured a gold-silver finish in the junior men's vault event at the Asian Artistic Gymnastics Championships in Zunyi, China, on Sunday. Harshit topped with 13.649, while Akshat finished second with 13.433. "It is a great achievement by the boys," India men's artistic gymnastics coach Rakesh Patra said.



Champions: Velavan, left, and Abhay.

Abhay-Velavan duo wins at Asian Doubles C'ships

Sports Bureau

Abhay Singh and Velavan Senthilkumar won the men's crown for a third consecutive year at the Asian doubles squash championships in Sarawak, Malaysia, on Sunday.

The Abhay-Velavan combine, seeded No. 1, rallied to beat Pakistan's second seeds Nasir Iqbal and Noor Zaman 7-11, 11-7, 11-2 in 47 minutes, in a repeat of last year's final.

Clark leads by six shots as Scheffler makes his move

GOLF

Associated Press
SOUTHAMPTON

Not even Shinnecock Hills and its strongest test of the week in the U.S. Open could match the toughness of Wyndham Clark on Saturday.

Clark had a collection of par saves around the turn as Scottie Scheffler was making a move.

He poured it on with a fairway metal to four feet for an eagle on the par-5 16th for a par 70 that gave him a six-shot lead.

The course did its part, even after the strongest wind subsided. Only two players managed to break par in the third round – Emiliano Grillo and World No. 1 Scheffler with a 69.

Clark nearly joined them. After all his great saves, he missed a five-foot par putt on the final hole and finished at seven-under 203, the lowest 54-hole score ever at Shinnecock



Good going: Scheffler, one of two players to go under par on Saturday, was six strokes behind Clark. AFP

Hills, to give himself a chance to add another U.S. Open title to the one he captured in 2023.

Scheffler, who fell nine shots behind with a pair of bogeys at the start, shot 32 on the back nine by chipping in from 65 feet on the 14th for the start of three straight birdies. His one big lament was missing a 4-foot birdie putt on the final hole. He moved into the last group when Shinnecock Hills did a number on everyone else.

Sam Stevens, who closed within two shots of Clark on the front, started

the back nine with three straight bogeys and closed with six straight pars for a 72. Tom Kim dropped two shots at the wrong time and also shot 72. Sahithi Theegala had one birdie, one bogey and 16 pars for a 70.

All of them were at 1-under 209, leaving only five players under par.

Top scores: 203: Clark 64-69-70; 209: Scheffler 72-68-69, Theegala 72-67-70, Kim 70-67-72, Stevens 68-69-72; 210: Mitchell 70-70-70, Grillo 70-70-67, Burns 71-68-71, Schauffele 71-66-73; 211: Fleetwood 70-71-70, Morikawa 73-65-73, Fitzpatrick 67-70-74.

India regains Nations Cup, back in women's Pro League

Press Trust of India
AUCKLAND

India defeated host New Zealand 2-0 in the final to win its second FIH Women's Nations Cup title and secure a promotion to the FIH Women's Pro League here on Sunday.

Navneet Kaur gave India an early lead in the fourth minute before Sunelita Toppo doubled the advantage in the 15th.

The team then produced a stellar defensive display to protect the lead and emerge triumphant. India had won the inaugural edition in 2022.

Lalremsiami won the Player-of-the-Match award, while Deepika with six goals finished as the joint-top scorer in the tournament.

SNAPSHOTS

India gets the better of the Netherlands

The Indian men's hockey team notched up a 3-2 win over the Netherlands in its last match of the FIH Pro League Rotterdam leg on Sunday. Goals from Jugraj Singh (18th minute), Abhishek (27), and Rajinder Singh (56) helped India secure its second outright victory of the leg against the Dutch side. Pepijn van der Heijden (19) and Koen Bijen (59) scored for the hosts.

Para shuttler Thulasimathi earns two gold medals

India's Thulasimathi Murugesan won two gold and a bronze in the France Para Badminton International in Mulhouse on Sunday. In the women's singles final (SU5), Thulasimathi defeated France's Maud Lefort 21-11, 21-14 and in women's doubles (SL3-SU5), she combined with Manasi Joshi to overcome Indonesia's World No.1 pair of Leani Ratri Oktila and Khalimatus Satiyak 19-21, 21-15, 21-11. Thulasimathi and Nitesh Kumar lost to Indonesia's Leani Ratri and Himat Ramdani 14-21, 7-21 in the mixed doubles (SL3-SU5) semifinals.



Cock-a-hoop: An ecstatic Salima celebrates the triumph with her teammates. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

ment along with USA's Ashley Sessa.

India remained unbeaten throughout the campaign, defeating USA 3-2, Japan 2-1, and Uruguay 3-2 in pool matches before routing Chile 6-0 in the semifinal.

To recognise the team's

achievements, Hockey India has announced a cash award of ₹ three lakh for each player and ₹1.5 lakh for each member of the support staff.

The result (final): India 2 (Navneet 4, Sunelita 15) bt New Zealand 0.



Delighted: The Indian players celebrate a strike. FIH



Thulasimathi.

Vritti breaks 800m freestyle record

Vritti Agarwal clocked 9:05.47 to smash Richa Mishra's 15-year-old women's 800m freestyle record and win the gold medal on the concluding day of the National aquatics championships in Ahmedabad on Sunday. Telangana swimmer Vritti's record-breaking performance helped her register the 'best Indian time' as well. Rishabh Das went below two minutes (1:59.90) to better his own

mark and win men's 200m backstroke with another 'best Indian time'.

Aryan, who claimed three gold and a bronze and set two new records, and Saanvi Deshwal, who bagged three gold and a silver and rewrote one record, were chosen as the best swimmers.

The results (winners only): Men: 400m freestyle: Aryan Nehra (Guj) 3:55.34; **200m backstroke:** Rishabh Das (Mah) 1:59.90 (NMR, Old 2:00.65; Rishabh Das, 2025); **50m breaststroke:** Danush Suresh (TN) 28.38; **200m butterfly:** Bikram Changmai (RSPB) 2:02.50.

Women: 800m freestyle: Vritti Agarwal (TG) 9:05.47 (NMR, Old 9:06.31; Richa Mishra, 2011); **50m butterfly:** Nina Venkatesh (Kar) 27.67 (NMR, Old 27.74; Nina Venkatesh, 2023); **4x100m medley relay:** Karnataka (Nina Venkatesh, S. Lakshya, Tanishi Gupta, Dhindhidi Desinghu) 4:18.72 (NMR, Old 4:23.65; Maharashtra, 2023).

EDUCATIONPLUS

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How learners learn

If every student is to be a productive learner, a paradigm shift from generic delivery to individualised mode is essential

K. Elango

“Attending classes is a waste of time. What I learn in a one-hour lecture, I can grasp in five minutes from YouTube. I am better informed of the latest trends in a flawless and fluent presentation.” This statement from my college-going son during a conversation disturbed me deeply.

While the claim may be true in his case, it gave rise to a nagging question: ‘Why do learners remain at the same level of academic competence throughout the 12 years of schooling?’ This led to a close observation of the performance patterns of students passing through our system.

Even if we categorise students as advanced, average and mediocre, ideally, as they progress through the educational ladder, their capabilities should be enhanced as a result of the teaching-learning processes. But their performances remain static, especially in the latter two categories. This leads to the question: Does the teacher-learner interface really make any difference?

Mismatch exists

Several pedagogical methods – inquiry-based, project-based, and activity-based learning – were adopted to make learning effective for all. Further, shifts to learner-centric and communicative approaches were trumpeted

as leading to a better learning ecosystem. Despite all this, the mismatch between teaching and learning exists, which is evident as the three categories of learners largely continue to persist.

The myth of learner learns what teacher teaches has been debunked. Following textbooks and attentively listening doesn’t automatically result in learning. The oft-quoted, “If they can’t learn the way we teach, we need to teach the way they learn” demands an urgent transformational trajectory.

At the high-school level, students must be made aware of what learning is and how to learn. They must be steered to reflect metacognitively and identify whether they are visual learners, auditory learners, reading/writing learners, or kinesthetic learners. This shift calls for teachers to use multi-modal approaches, even within a 40-minute class period, alongside the prescribed text. Other print texts such as excerpts from newspapers and magazines, e-texts in multiple formats such as blogs, vlogs, infographics, videos, film clips, reels, and music must feature in every class to keep all the learners hooked.

Such a practice validates Howard Gardner’s concept of multiple intelligences and facilitates different learners benefitting from the varieties of texts, clubbed with multiple activities.

The architecture of educational institutions with rows of classrooms, each stacked with benches and desks, scarcely provides any space for learner-centred engagements. It is solely designed for teacher-centric modes. Yet, the open spaces within campuses allow us to adopt Tagore’s visionary model of Santiniketan. The availability of classrooms need not restrict students, as they eagerly welcome activities conducted outdoors.

Linguistic skills

There is also the issue of acquisition of linguistic skills: speaking can be learnt only by speaking, writing only writing, listening by listening and reading by reading. The lament of poor English-speaking skill is rooted in dual realities: the rarity of speaking activities in classes and the emphasis on formal presentations.

Instead, if students could be divided into pairs, triads or small groups and speaking activities conducted outdoors, with a stress on informal communication, could lead to mastering the skill. The informal communicative competence gained in this

manner is sure to help them perform better in formal contexts and not vice versa. Likewise, other skills could be mastered by resorting to the same principle.

Yet another significant aspect to trigger learning among students is employing different classroom strategies such as challenge, persuasion, competition, praise, reward, embarrassment, stimulation, and goal-setting. These must vary with individuals and even with the same student over time. If we were to cultivate the habit of productive learning in every student, a paradigm shift from generic delivery to an individualised mode is a must.

Only such an approach can elevate average and mediocre students to higher levels, transforming classroom dynamics and the nature of learning. For the classroom interface to become purposeful, the central concern ought to be not how teachers teach but how learners learn.

The writer is a retired Professor of English, Anna University, and Chief Executive Chair of English Language Teachers’ Association of India (ELTAI).

P.V. Navaneethakrishnan

A recent proposal submitted to the National Medical Commission suggested replacing the percentile-based cut-off for NEET-UG with a percentage model to decide the merit list for admissions to programmes including MBBS and BDS. Percentiles become redundant only when the same set of questions is used for all candidates, as is done in this exam. Unlike raw marks, percentiles cannot be negative; hence, they can be used to prescribe a low or even a negative cut-off eligibility mark.

Recently, after the second round of counselling for admission to PG programmes in medicine, the National Board of Exami-

Ranking for reality

The percentage-percentile conundrum in NEET



nations in Medical Sciences reduced the eligibility cut-off in the percentile ranking in NEET-PG for SC, ST, and OBC categories to zero (equivalent to minus 40 raw marks). The repeated relaxation of admission standards may be detrimental to the importance of the NEET-PG exam. Several academic experts have

argued that a negative final score in the raw marks should be considered a disqualification, as it may indicate a lack of minimum level of competence required.

One solution could be to conduct NEET-PG at least twice a year for a higher number of eligible candidates, which in turn could allow a higher cut-off in the percentile list. Another way is to remove negative marking for wrong answers. A third option is to make candidates with negative final scores ineligible

for admission and debar them from appearing for the exam for a year or two.

The Inter-se-merit of Candidates in the Information Bulletin NEET (UG)-2026 lists Physics as a tie-breaker for the same marks in Biology and Chemistry. This is redundant because the tie occurs due to the same total marks in the three subjects. Clause ‘h’ also states that the final stage will be resolved by a random process with the guidance of an independent expert committee. In fairness to students, information on this process should be part of the bulletin.

Views are personal

The writer is Former Director, Entrance Exams and Admission, Anna University, Chennai.

SCHOLARSHIPS

AICTE Swanath Scholarship

An initiative of the AICTE. **Eligibility:** Indian nationals who are enrolled in a full-time regular degree or diploma programme at an AICTE-approved institutions and are wards of Armed Forces and Central Paramilitary Forces personnel martyred in action or PwD parents (above 80% disability in accident) or

whose parents suffer from a critical life-threatening disease, or who have lost one/ both parents due to COVID-19 and have a family income of less than ₹800,000 per annum. **Rewards:** ₹50,000 a year for duration of course Application: Online **Deadline:** October 31 www.b4s.in/edge/ASST2

AICTE Pragati Scholarship for Girls

Offered by the AICTE **Eligibility:** Girls who are

Indian nationals and have secured admission to the first year of a diploma/ degree or in are in the second year through lateral entry in an AICTE-approved institution and have an annual family income of less than ₹800,000. **Rewards:** ₹50,000 one time. **Application:** Online **Deadline:** October 31 www.b4s.in/edge/ASSST3

Sage IT India Scholarship

Offered by the Sage IT Inc.

Eligibility: Indian students between 17 and 30 years enrolled in a recognised Indian institution must submit an article on what it means to thrive in an AI-first world that has not been published anywhere else previously. **Rewards:** ₹50,000 (one-time) paid directly to institution **Application:** Online **Deadline:** November 15 www.b4s.in/edge/SGIT4

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com

SAVE THE DATE

AI Adoption Survey

QS I-GAUGE has launched an AI Adoption Survey for Educators, to assess educators’ perceptions of AI, current usage patterns, and readiness to adopt AI in professional roles. **Who Can Participate:** Faculty members from schools across all educational boards, colleges, universities and other higher education institutions across India. To participate, school educators can visit <https://survey.zohopublic.in/zs/jbMBY6> Higher education faculty can visit

<https://survey.zohopublic.in/zs/yzBMBR>

Admissions

IIM-Lucknow invites applications to its B.Sc. Artificial Intelligence and Business Analytics programme, beginning on August 18. Students will have the option to transition to the Tech-MBA programme (scheduled to commence in 2027-28) after completing their third year, and convert their studies into an integrated dual-degree programme. **Eligibility:** 10+2 with Physics Chemistry and Maths as main subjects and qualification in JEE Advanced.

Deadline: July 3 <https://shorturl.at/slkME>

The ESCP School of Technology, Paris, France, has launched a three-year, English-taught Bachelor in Management, Science and Technology programme, which will commence in September 2027 and be taught across the institute’s campuses in Paris, Turin, and London. **Eligibility:** Students who have passed high school from any education system <https://shorturl.at/TbHdX>

Ashoka University has announced the final round of applications for its M.A.

Economics and Data Analytics programme.

Eligibility: Four-year UG degree or a Master’s degree; preference will be given to those with training in Economics, Computer Science, Engineering, Maths, Statistics, or other quantitative fields. **Deadline:** June 29 <https://pg-application.ashoka.edu.in/>

IBCA invites applications for its diploma and certification courses in Culinary and Pastry Arts. **Eligibility:** Pass in 10+2 from a recognised board **Deadline:** June 30 <https://www.chefibpa.com/>



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BRIC-RGCB invites application for admission to the Master’s Degree in Biotechnology (MSc Biotechnology)

Advt No: RGCB/MSc/2026-1 June 18, 2026

BRIC-RGCB MSc program is affiliated to the Regional Centre for Biotechnology (RCB) an “Institution of National Importance” providing education, training and research established by the Department of Biotechnology, Government of India under the auspices of the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO). This programme has duration of two years inclusive of four semesters. All students admitted to the MSc programme shall receive a monthly stipend of ₹ 6000 for the first year and ₹ 8000 for the second year.

ELIGIBILITY:

- All candidates must have a valid GAT-B score.
- Final selection of the students will be based on the GAT-B rank and the Cut-off score/rank fixed by BRIC-RGCB for each category.
- Students must have 60% aggregate marks (or an equivalent grade point average) in Bachelor’s degree in any branch of Life Science or Medicine as per the UGC guidelines.

Last Date to receive the filled application: **On or before 30th June, 2026**

Complete information, application format & other details are available on the BRIC-RGCB website (<https://rgcb.res.in/MSc2026/>).

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2025 Overall India: 96 | World: 1501+ | Subject Ranking: 1001-1250 CS: (1000+)

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SCAN TO APPLY

INBRIEF



India boxers punch their way to 12-medal haul in Czechia

India's Commonwealth Games-bound boxers finished with a rich haul of 12 medals, including eight golds at the invitational 56th Grand Prix Ustí nad Labem in Czechia.

The results (final): Women: 51kg: Sakshi Chaudhary bt Mayssoun Bourega (Fra) 5-0; **54kg:** Preeti Pawar bt Jeysa Marcel (Fra) 5-0; **60kg:** Priya Ghanghas bt Barbora Maxova (Cze) 5-0; **65kg:** Luca Mamori (Hun) bt Parveen Hooda 4-1; **75kg:** Lovlina Borgohain bt Melissa Gemini (Ita) 5-0. **Men: 55kg:** Jadumani Singh bt Abdul Burton (Eng) 4-1; **60kg:** Sachin bt Veres Rohland (Hun) 5-0; **65kg:** Giacomo Giannotti bt Aditya Pratap Yadav 3-2; **80kg:** Ankush bt Florian Daniel (Cze) 5-0; **90kg:** Roselin Bachevski bt Kapil Pokhariya 4-1; **90+kg:** Narender bt Davit Chaloyan (Arm) 3-2.

Jyoti wins 48kg gold in World Boxing Cup 2

Jyoti Gulia outclassed Uzbekistan's Farzona Fozilova 5-0 in the women's 48kg final to clinch India's lone gold medal at the World Boxing Cup 2 in Guiyang on Sunday. India added three silver medals. In 51kg final, Minakshi lost 0-5 to China's Wu Yu, Prachi went down 0-5 to Uzbekistan's Nigina Uktamo in the 57kg final and Deepak came second in the 70kg category after going down 0-5 to Kazakhstan's Abilaikhan Zhussupov. India had already confirmed two bronze medals (Jugnoo in 85kg & Nikhil in 55kg).

India begins with easy win in AVC Men's Volleyball Cup

India began its AVC Men's Volleyball Cup campaign with a 25-23, 25-19, 25-14 win over New Zealand in Ahmedabad on Saturday.

Asian Relays: Indian women's 4x100m team wins gold

India's Srabani Nanda, S.S. Sneha, Sudeshna Shivankar and Tamanna clinched the gold medal in the women's 4x100m relay, clocking 43.85 seconds, on the final day of the Asian Relays C'ships in Shaoxing on Sunday. The mixed 4x400m relay team (Theerthesh Shetty, Poovamma M.R., Bharath Sridhar, Neeru Pathak) won the silver, behind Kazakhstan (3:17.06). The mixed 4x100m team of Pranav Gaurav, Tamanna, Animesh Kujur and Sneha won the bronze behind Thailand and China.

D'artagnan triumphs

BENGALURU: P. Shroff-trained D'artagnan (G. Vivek up) won the Zavaray S. Poonawalla Colts Championship Stakes (1,600m), the chief event of the races held here on Sunday (June 21). The winner is owned by Mr & Mrs. Vijay B. Shirke & Mr. Jay V. Shirke rep. Horse Haven Breeding and Racing Pvt. Ltd., Mr & Mrs. Farouq K. Rattoney rep. Hyperion Bloodstock Pvt. Ltd., Mr. Mehernosh H. Deboo, Mrs. Liane Luthria, Mr. Milan Luthria & Mrs. Daisy K.D.B. Mehta & Mr. Darashaw Keki Mehta rep. Darashaw Racing & Breeding Pvt. Ltd., Mr & Mrs. Farouq K. Rattoney, Mr. Sameer F. Rattoney & Mr. Zaher F. Rattoney rep. by Hyperion Bloodstock Pvt. Ltd. Vivek confidently kept his colt a handy second last position till the bend before manoeuvring the mount from wide outside in the home stretch. D'artagnan responded well, started galloping tremendously and overtook the leader Stud Poker while passing 200m to win resolutely.

THE RESULTS:
1. GUINDY PLATE (DIV. II), 1,200M: AMAZING STORM (Bhawani S) 1, Anzac Parade (Aditya W) 2, Dr. Colchester (Aruil) 3 and N R I Millennium (A. Asban) 4, 1-3/4, 1-3/4 and Nk. 1m, 15.4s. \$155 (w), 34, 12 and 25 (p), SHP: 30, THP: 81, FP: 474, Q: 167, Trinella: 12,566/5,385, Exacta: 48,608/20,832. Favourite: Anzac Parade. Owner: Mr. S. Saleem Shah. Trainer: M. Rajendra Singh.
2. BERGAMO PLATE (DIV. II), 1,100M: MAGESTIC PERSONA (Vishal) 1, Aphelion (Sandesh) 2, Super Kind (Salman Khan) 3 and CR Seven (Kiran Rai) 4, 8-1/4, 3 and 3-1/2. 1m, 06.61s. \$25 (w), 13, 10 and 17 (p), SHP: 23, THP: 41, FP: 36, Q: 16, Trinella: 180/132, Exacta: 34/101. Favourite: Aphelion. Owners: Mr. R.M. Ramaswamy & Mr. M. Venkatarama. Trainer: V. Lokanath.
3. INTERNATIONAL DAY OF YOGA PLATE (1,200M): RIZZ (Sandesh) 1, Osaka (Suraj) 2, Flavianus (Neeraj) 3 and Astrid (Arvind K) 4, 5-1/2, 3/4 and 1. 1m, 13.18s. \$44 (w), 14, 10 and 23 (p), SHP: 26, THP: 53, FP: 151, Q: 39, Trinella: 568/419, Exacta: 3,621/1,773. Favourite: Osaka. Owners: Diamond Band Rac Syn Pvt. Ltd., M/s. Rapar Galloping Stars LLP, Mr. Jehan Jehangir Sataravala & Dr. Syed Almuiddin Arif. Trainer: Adhiraj S. Jodha.
4. NOBLE PRINCE PLATE (1,800M): DARDANUS (Antony) 1, Stentorian (Darshan) 2, Mandate (Ajeemuddin) 3 and Oxytocin (Kiran Rai) 4, 1-1/4, 1/2 and 2-1/4. 1m, 52.94s. \$26 (w), 10, 41 and 14 (p), SHP: 177, THP: 35, FP: 645, Q: 658, Trinella: 3,099/1,123,

Exacta: 62,553 (carried over). Favourite: Dardanus. Owner: Mr. Joydeep Datta Gupta. Trainer: Bharath Singh.
5. CIVIL SERVICE CUP (2,000M): PROKOFIEV (Akshay K) 1, Caccini (G. Vivek) 2, Ice Of Fire (A. Asban) 3 and Star Studded (Yash) 4, 2-1/2, 10 and 1-1/4. 2m, 05.94s. \$30 (w), 22 and 13 (p), SHP: 25, THP: 24, FP: 54, Q: 24, Trinella: 60/31, Exacta: 154/105. Favourite: Caccini. Owners: Poonawalla Racing & Breeding Pvt. Ltd. rep. by Mr. Zavaray S. Poonawalla, Mrs. Behroze Z. Poonawalla, Mr. Yohan Z. Poonawalla, Mrs. Michelle Y. Poonawalla, Ms. Delna Z. Poonawalla, Mrs. Simone Poonawalla Pandole, Mr. Rishad N. Pandole & Ms. Tania Y. Poonawalla. Trainer: Prasanna Kumar.
6. ZAVARAY S. POONAWALLA COLTS CHAMPIONSHIP STAKES (1,600M): D'ARTAGNAN (DEAUVILLE-EXCEPTION) G. VIVEK 1, Stud Poker (Kameko-Cat's Claw) Antony 2, Knotty Emperor (Gusto-Par Excellence) Suraj 3 and Zayvan (Ten Sovereigns-Call Me Sweetheart) Yash 4, 1-1/4, 4 and 5. 1m, 36.37s. \$16 (w), 10, 11 and 13 (p), SHP: 23, THP: 31, FP: 37, Q: 14, Trinella: 76/31, Exacta: 162/84. Favourite: D'artagnan. Owners: Mr & Mrs. Vijay B. Shirke & Mr. Jay V. Shirke rep. Horse Haven Breeding and Racing Pvt. Ltd., Mr & Mrs. Farouq K. Rattoney rep. Hyperion Bloodstock Pvt. Ltd., Mr. Mehernosh H. Deboo, Mrs. Liane Luthria, Mr. Milan Luthria & Mrs. Daisy K.D.B. Mehta & Mr. Darashaw Keki Mehta rep. Darashaw Racing & Breeding Pvt. Ltd., Mr & Mrs. Farouq K. Rattoney, Mr. Sameer F. Rattoney & Mr. Zaher F. Rattoney rep. by Hyperion Bloodstock Pvt. Ltd. Trainer: P. Shroff.
7. BERGAMO PLATE (DIV. I), 1,100M: STEFFEN (Vishal S) 1, Hushed (Vishal) 2, Supreme Success (Yash) 3 and Zayana (Pavan) 4, 2, 1-3/4 and 7. 1m, 07.18s. \$60 (w), 18, 10 and 18 (p), SHP: 32, THP: 38, FP: 173, Q: 51, Trinella: 197/243, Exacta: 1,299/481. Favourite: Hushed. Owner: Mr. P. Arun Kumar. Trainer: S. John.
8. GUINDY PLATE (DIV. I), 1,200M: MY SOLITAIRE (Antony) 1, Legendary Impact (Vishal) 2, Estefania (Shreyas S) 3 and LG's Script (Vaibhav) 4, 1-1/2, 1-3/4 and 3/4. 1m, 14.60s. \$30 (w), 17, 21 and 17 (p), SHP: 41, THP: 68, FP: 120, Q: 45, Trinella: 433/166, Exacta: 2,456/1,052. Favourite: My Solitaire. Owner: Mr. R. Ramesh. Trainer: S. Shoban Babu.
Jackpot: ₹4,616; runner-up: 408; mini jackpot: 1,674; treble (0): 822; (ii): 456.

SNAPSHOTS

Matsuyama wins men's foil gold
Kyosuke Matsuyama won gold in the men's foil on a day of upsets in the 26th Asian senior fencing championships at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi on Sunday. Hong Kong's Cheung Ka Long, a reigning two-time Olympic champion, suffered a shock defeat to South Korea's Im Cheolwoo in the quarterfinals. Cheolwoo went on to claim silver.

Defending champion Ryan Choi was also knocked out in the quarters, the Hong Kong fencer succumbing to Matsuyama. In women's epee, Irina Bakaldina clinched a first-ever individual gold for Kazakhstan in this category by defeating Hong Kong's Kaylin Hsieh.

Australia sweeps T201 series
Mitchell Marsh smashed 60 off 28 balls (7x4, 4x6) as Australia completed a

3-0 T201 series sweep over Bangladesh, winning by seven wickets in Chattogram on Sunday. Australia had already wrapped up the series after winning the first two matches and made light work of the hosts, chasing a modest target of 110 in just 11 overs. **The scores:** Bangladesh 109/8 in 20 overs (Towhid 61 n.o.) lost to Australia 112/3 in 11 overs (Marsh 60). **Toss:** Bangladesh. **PoM:** Marsh; **Pos:** Renshaw.



NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES

In this Hon'ble High Court, Chennai monitored auctions (in C.O.P.(MD)No. 15498/2024 and batch cases), commercial properties of defaulted financial establishment, namely Neomax Properties Pvt. Ltd. and its sister concerns, are proposed to be brought for sale by way of E-tender cum E-auction through the MSTC website (<https://www.mstcecommerce.com/auction/home/nmmp/index.jsp>). The interested bidders may participate in the event by registering in MSTC and depositing Pre-Bid EMD on the website. Further, for the details of the properties and updates, the bidders may visit the EOW website (www.tneow.tn.gov.in).

Sl. NO	Name of the Project	Details of the Asset	Land Area	Built-Up Area (in SFT)
1.	COURTRALLAM RESORTS Ayiraperi Village, Tenkasi Taluk, Tenkasi District	RCC Building (A/C & Non-A/C Garden Restaurant, 2 Banquet Halls, Board Room, DVD Theatre, Suit Rooms, Spa, Reception Office Building with Suit Rooms, A/C Bar Building) & Swimming Pool, Artificial Falls, Resorts Cottage Building, Empty Lands. Upset price : Rs.43,19,80,000/- Prebid EMD : RS 4,31,98,000/-	30.69 Acres	34991.25 Sq.ft (approx.)
2.	KODAIROAD-DRIVE-IN HOTEL, Jambudurai Kottai Village, Nilakottai Taluk, Dindigul District	Drive-in Hotel constructed in Tress Work & STP Plant (Dining area, Party Hall, Kitchen, Servant shed (Gents / Ladies), Toilet (all with GI Sheet Roof) Upset price : Rs. 5,06,25,000 /- Prebid EMD : RS 50,62,500/-	2.64 Acres	13132.44 Sq.ft (approx.)
3.	KODAI ROAD- CATERING INSTITUTE, Jambudurai Kottai Village, Nilakottai Taluk, Dindigul District	Catering Institute (Ground floor and Portico with RCC roof, Storage shed, connecting shed with GI sheet roof) Upset price: Rs.5,72,50,000/- Prebid EMD : RS 57,25,000/-	3.12 Acres	12395.25 Sq.ft (approx.)
4.	PAVER BLOCK FACTORY Keelachinnampatti Village, Vadiptirai Taluk, Madurai	Factory Building with Lands (Main Building with GI Roof, Side Building Keelachinnampatti Village, Vadiptirai Taluk, Madurai) Upset price : Rs. 1,42,18,125 /- Prebid EMD : RS 14,21,813/- (Property attached by ED, No-objection has been given by the ED to auction the property, as per the Hon'ble High Court order, translate to tamil)	2.49 Acres	11319 Sq.ft (approx.)

Important Schedule & Information

Date of site inspection and document verification:	22.06.2026 to 21.07.2026
Date of Assistance to the bidders by the MSTC officials for Registration in the MSTC Portal (at the EOW office Madurai)	02.07.2026 and 03.07.2026
Date and time of auction	22.07.2026, 10.30 AM to 23.07.2026, 5.00 PM (Auto extension applicable)

* Pre-Bid EMD (Except Eligible Neomax Depositors*): Must be deposited well in advance as per the MSTC auction catalogue requirements. Minimum Incremental Value: Rs. 10,000/- The properties are to be auctioned on an 'as is where is' condition on the basis of the title deeds on record. It is for the bidders to satisfy themselves of the title and also the physical details and participate in the auction on their own best judgment. The successful bids, once zeroed in by the MSTC, will be confirmed only after placing it before the Hon'ble Court. The Hon'ble Court, for the reasons of adequacy of price or otherwise, has the right to confirm or reject the bid. In case of rejection, the EMD amount will be returned to the participant(s). * Once the bid is confirmed, the entire sale price has to be deposited by the successful bidders (Except the Neomax depositors who bid without pre-bid EMD) within ten (10) days from the date of confirmation of the auction, failing which the EMD will be forfeited.

* Neomax depositors who claim exemption from Pre-Bid EMD can view their status in the excel sheet posted on the EOW website. Contact Details: For Inspection/Queries: Contact EOW at **9080381065/8778245559** (10.30 AM to 5.00 PM on working days) and seowmadurai2@gmail.com. For Registration & Auction Helpdesk: Contact MSTC at 9499054101/102/103/104 (10.30 AM to 5.00 PM on working days) and sroop9@mstcindia.in. Visit www.mstcecommerce.com or www.mstcindia.co.in to participate.

Place: Chennai
Date: 20.06.2026. DIPR/555/Tender/2026

Competent Authority/ Superintendent of Police,
EOW, South Zone.

CRICKET

Shayan Acharya
DAMBULLA

A final is supposed to be a contest. But Vaibhav Sooryavanshi had other ideas.

The 15-year-old's record-shattering 29-ball 94 (10x4, 8x6) laid the foundation for India-A's imposing 377 for nine before the visitors thrashed Sri Lanka-A by 66 runs to lift the tri-series title at the Rangiri International Stadium on Sunday.

A sizeable crowd had turned up hoping the home side would make the most of familiar conditions. Instead, it witnessed a batting exhibition by the Indian teen.

Sooryavanshi's first five deliveries disappeared to the boundary – three fours

Smiles all around: The India-A players delivered when it mattered most to clinch the crown.

and two sixes. Eleven balls into his innings, he had already raced to a fifty, the fastest in List A cricket. With the Sri Lankan bowlers repeatedly missing

their lengths, the south-paw punished anything in his arc as India-A surged to 100 in just 6.3 overs.

Priyansh Arya played the perfect foil after being

handed an early reprieve while Sooryavanshi dominated the attack in the 132-run stand. For a while, the fastest List A century looked inevitable. But Sri

Lanka-A captain Sahan Arachchige induced a miscued hit that was held at mid-off, ending a breath-taking knock.

By then, however, the damage had been done.

After both openers departed, Ruturaj Gaikwad and captain Tilak Varma put on an 84-run stand for the third wicket. The scoring rate dipped, but India-A remained firmly in control. En route his 90-ball 67, Tilak stitched another half-century partnership with Kumar Kushagra, before three quick wickets briefly threatened to stall the charge.

Late cameos from Vipraj Nigam (27 off 20) and Anukul Roy, whose unbeaten 39 came off just 15 balls, ensured India-A finished with the highest total of the tournament.

Sri Lanka-A put up a

fight despite setbacks.

Ashok Sharma, replacing Anshul Kamboj, impressed with his pace, while Yash Thakur's three wickets kept Sri Lanka-A on the back foot. Sadeera Samarawickrama and Arachchige briefly revived the chase with a 53-run stand until Ashok struck.

Wanuja Sahan and Vijayakanth Viyaskanth added 77 for the seventh wicket, but Vipraj's three wickets meant India-A was in command. The day, though, belonged to Sooryavanshi, who saved his best for the final and turned the title clash into a spectacle.

The scores: India-A 377/9 in 50 overs (Sooryavanshi 94, Ruturaj 40, Tilak 67) bt Sri Lanka-A 311 in 47.1 overs (Samarawickrama 52, Sahan 62, Yash Thakur 3/45, Vipraj 3/60). **Toss:** Sri Lanka-A. **PoM:** Sooryavanshi.

Kanitkar sir gave me a free hand to play freely: Sooryavanshi

Shayan Acharya
DAMBULLA

A couple of days before the tri-nation series final, as Vaibhav Sooryavanshi walked out of the nets after a long and gruelling batting session under the scorching sun, a handful of local fans gathered around him, hoping to click pictures.

The teenager obliged to most requests, but the demands kept growing. One picture led to two, two led to three, and so on...

It reached a point where Sooryavanshi had to rush to catch the team bus as the India-A team was leaving the Rangiri International Stadium premises.

As the local security staff eventually escorted him away, one of them joked: "Let him score first... give him some time."

The runs weren't flow-

ing for the young southpaw yet. Coming on the back of a remarkable IPL season, Sooryavanshi couldn't convert his starts in the tri-nation series. The pressure, naturally, was mounting.

Hearing the remark, he smiled and quietly boarded the team bus. Who would have thought that the 15-year-old was saving his best for the last?

In the final against Sri Lanka-A on Sunday, Sooryavanshi's modus operandi was simple: miss your line or length and I'll make you pay.

"There was no pressure on me," Sooryavanshi said. "The idea was to execute what I had planned for in the first 10 overs and then take it forward. That was the plan and it worked."

When runs weren't coming, he consulted India-A coach Hrishikesh Ka-

The idea was to execute what I had planned for in the first 10 overs and take it forward

nitkar to sort things out.

"The conditions were challenging here, and I was not able to execute my plans in the last few games. But I could address that with the guidance of the coaches. So, it was about going out there and executing the plans," he added.

"I sat down with Hrishi sir to discuss a few things and he gave me a free hand to play freely," Sooryavanshi told *The Hindu*.

Having worked with him since the under-19 days, Sooryavanshi knew that Kanitkar's advice would be crucial.

"Even when I struggled, he told me that, '*tu apna*

natural game khel, zyada soch mat' (you play your natural game and don't think too much about anything else). That motivated me and I continued to back myself... I'm happy that things worked out well."

While a record-breaking innings will forever remain special, he doesn't want to think too much about the missed hundred (94, 29b, 10x4, 8x6) in the final.

As he leaves for Ireland and England with the Indian senior men's team, Sooryavanshi will start afresh with a lot of confidence.

"Many people don't know, but I have played some One-dayers... so it was good to take on the bowlers today," he said with a smile, after being adjudged the Player-of-the-Match.

Take it easy: Sooryavanshi said the coaches ensured there was no pressure on him. SLC



CH-CH



CH-CH



CH-CH



CH-CH



CH-CH



CH-CH



CH-CH



CH-CH



Creating a buzz: Gurnoor, Arshdeep and Prasidh have shown that pace is the ace. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP, SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR & R. RAGU

India’s GenNext pace battery — hungry, promising and effective

With two of the next three Test series in the subcontinent, the coaching group’s brief will revolve around keeping the quicks fresh, relevant and topped up skill-wise with the 50-over World Cup in southern Africa next year as the ultimate goal

R. Kaushik
CHENNAI

Ruthlessly efficient. How often have we used those words in conjunction to describe India’s fast bowlers on home turf? And not just any fast bowlers, but those young in both age and experience so far as international cricket is concerned.

It’s been a productive fortnight for the national team, not because it completed expected conquests of an out-of-its-depth Afghanistan in the one-off Test in New Chandigarh and the three One-Day Internationals that followed, but for the personnel that drove these outcomes. True, the established names stepped up – skipper Shubman Gill and K.L. Rahul and Ishan Kishan readily spring to mind from a batting standpoint, with Rohit Sharma and Yashavi Jaiswal just a half-notch below. But it’s the success of a slew of relative newcomers in the bowling department that has sparked genuine excitement and the promise that tomorrow might not be as bleak as feared.

India bid goodbye to the magic of R. Ashwin some 18 months back. The Tamil Nadu off-spinner’s destroyer-in-arms, fellow tweaker Ravindra Jadeja, isn’t too far from riding away into the Test sunset. Mohammed Shami seems to be permanently out of favour for no fault of his other than, one suspects, ruffling the egos of a few good men. Jasprit Bumrah’s protesting body needs careful monitoring, Kuldeep Yadav seems to have hit a trough. A host of fast bowlers who arrived with hype and hoopla are gasping for relevance, among them Mukesh Kumar, Akashdeep Singh and Anshul Kamboj. Among the fans, if not among those who have been carefully charting the progress of the next rung, a sense of despondency was beginning to creep in.

It’s against this uncertain backdrop that the developments of the last two weeks must be viewed, weighed, measured and judged. The temptation to write off early successes as the by-products of a combination of beginners’ luck and a weak opposition might be huge, but it’s worth remembering that the likes of Manav Suthar and Gurnoor Brar and Prince Yadav themselves aren’t exactly established household names. In some ways, they were in the same boat as their opponents, having to conquer gremlins of self-doubt, having to grapple with thoughts of whether they belonged at the highest level. Which is exactly what makes their early statements at the highest level so impressive.

Suthar has stolen an early march in the quest to become a long-term weapon in the spinning arsenal in the red-ball game. The decision-makers in Indian cricket have been tracking him for a couple of years and, convinced that in the longer version his left-arm spin was a more potent threat than the same brand offered by Harsh Dubey, threw him into the deep end in New Chandigarh. The 23-year-old didn’t disappoint; he got a wicket with his fourth ball in Test cricket, went on to pick up six wickets in his first innings as a Test



With Nitish lining up as a fast-bowling all-rounder, a rarity in Indian cricket, alongside Hardik, and Harshit, Gurnoor, Prince and Nabi slotting in as serious contenders, the Indian fast-bowling cupboard looks a lot fuller than it was a couple of years back

bowler and finished the game with the Player of the Match award. It was a grand debut for one so young and with so much to offer. That he has since travelled to England to play for Warwickshire in the English County Championship is great news because even though the county game is no longer the finishing school as it once used to be, there is so much to learn for a young overseas spinner in England at this time of the summer when there isn’t a lot of assistance from the playing surfaces.

India play two Tests in Sri Lanka in August and Suthar can expect to link up alongside Jadeja (if fully fit) and Washington Sundar should the leadership group opts to look for greater batting depth too and therefore looks beyond Kuldeep. But as heartening as Suthar’s initiation has been, it’s the emergence of a small bunch of faster bowlers that will gladden the hearts of Gill and head coach Gautam Gambhir.

Surprise pick
Gurnoor was a somewhat contentious selection to the Test squad, ahead of Auqib Nabi, the 29-year-old from Jammu and Kashmir who has taken more than 100 wickets in the last two Ranji Trophy seasons and whose 60 wickets were crucial to the State lifting the title for the first time earlier this year. Gurnoor, 26, has fewer First Class wickets in a three-year career than Nabi in the season gone by alone, but his height (1.94 metres) and high pace are the points of difference. In the highest decision-making echelons, Nabi is seen as a bowler reliant on conditions – even though he took wickets across pitches of varying character throughout the whole of the last two years – whereas Brar is perceived as someone who can extract life anywhere, owing to his ability to procure steep bounce and his speed through the air.

Given the slant towards spin and the presence of Mohammed Siraj and Prasidh Krishna, the heroes of the series-levelling win in the Oval Test last August, Gurnoor warmed the bench in the one-off Test but impressed on his international debut in the truncated ODI in Dharamshala with three for 27. He took three more wickets in Lucknow on a shirtfront on which India posted more than 400, and rounded off the series with a somewhat expensive one for 49 at Chepauk on Saturday. Seven wickets from three home ODIs are terrific

returns for a 26-year-old in his first international foray and he has already made an early pitch for consideration for the 2027 50-over World Cup, which will be played on fresh, early-season pitches in South Africa, among other places, from next October.

“Yes, he did tick most of the boxes but there are some things that he can only learn from experience and hopefully, he is going to keep growing as a bowler,” Gill acknowledged. “If I am to be really critical, he did go for a little bit of runs. He was a little bit inconsistent at times, but he is young, he is playing his first series at the top level and he is bowling quick. He has got all the good signs that we want from a young, tall, fast bowler. And with experience, he is only going to get better.”

It’s obvious that chief selector Ajit Agarkar and his panel have invested a lot in Gurnoor, part of the targeted players that the BCCI and the CoE believe have the skills and the potential to make it to the next level and perform consistently there. Gurnoor is clearly a work in progress, which is only to be expected, but his height and pace are assets that should come in handy going forward. Hitherto, India’s pace bowling has revolved around Jasprit Bumrah (of course) and Siraj, with Harshit Rana looming as a third option when he isn’t injured. Now, there is a greater pool of players making a strong pitch, among them Prasidh, also tall like Gurnoor and also pacy, but with a lot more experience than Gurnoor, Prince and Nabi.

Prasidh finally seems to have shaken off the injury bug that has blighted his career; armed with greater confidence after his exploits in England, he is a more potent force who understands his bowling and the conditions a lot better. The fuller lengths he hit in bouncy Chennai on Saturday netted him his maiden international five-for, a definitive shot in the arm as he seeks to continue to be the prime force among the next crop, behind Bumrah and Siraj and Arshdeep Singh, who is only now beginning to get a decent run after a largely exclusive T20I career.

With Nitish Kumar lining up as a fast-bowling all-rounder, a rarity in Indian cricket, alongside Hardik Pandya, and Harshit, Gurnoor, Prince and Nabi slotting in as serious contenders, the Indian fast-bowling cupboard looks a lot fuller than it was a couple of years back. Much

of it has also to do with the streamlining process in which the Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru, under the stewardship of V.V.S. Laxman, has had a big but hardly publicised role to play. Troy Cooley worked tirelessly with the upcoming crop and can reflect on a job well done as he puts his feet up, having now exceeded the age threshold of 60. There was a time, when the leadership duo of Virat Kohli and Ravi Shastri ruled the roost, when India’s pace battery was the envy of most of the rest of the cricketing world. India haven’t yet got there, but there is no reason, if these young men keep their feet on the ground and are disciplined enough to ward off fitness-related injuries, they can’t reach those lofty heights again in the next couple of years.

“It’s fantastic,” Ryan ten Doeschate, the assistant coach, crowed the other day of the influx of pace riches all over again. “One of the big things when this coaching staff started out was always going to be the transition of the bowlers, particularly with guys like Shami not playing anymore. A couple of weeks ago when we got together in Chandigarh, to see those three young guys coming in and bowl, it was literally like a wow moment. The way Gurnoor has bowled in his first two games, to see a young Indian pacer hit 147, 148 (kmph) again, I’m sure you guys are all excited as we are.

“To balance the experience that this (ODI) team has – the guys have played a lot of cricket and won a lot of trophies – and to augment the talent and the experience and get them up to speed really, really quickly is going to be the challenge. We have to pick the best guys to do the job, which is obviously going to be the final piece of the puzzle. You need both elements – you need the experience and you continuously need to fill the pipeline with new guys coming in. You’ll agree that this squad is going to be in a very good space.”

With two of their next three Test series in the subcontinent, the coaching group’s brief will revolve around keeping the quicks fresh, relevant and topped up skill-wise with the longer World Cup as the ultimate goal. A larger pool will work as an insurance against injuries and loss of form, a luxury that hasn’t always been available to the Indians in the recent past. The signs are encouraging, but these are very early days yet and it’s important for all concerned to dip into the past and realise that the need of the hour is cautious optimism (well merited), not self-defeating, over-the-top grandstanding.

THE GIST

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Much of it has also to do with the streamlining process in which the Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru, under the stewardship of V.V.S. Laxman, has had a big but hardly publicised role to play

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There was a time, when the leadership duo of Virat Kohli and Ravi Shastri ruled the roost, when India’s pace unit was the envy of most of the rest of the cricketing world

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The signs are encouraging, but these are very early days yet and it’s important for all concerned to dip into the past and realise that the need of the hour is cautious optimism



Prince made his ODI debut in the second match of the recent series against the Afghans at the Ekana in Lucknow

Biochar offers a way to turn India’s farm smoke into ‘black gold’

When added to poor, degraded soils, biochar can increase their ability to store water and stimulate the growth of beneficial microbes; studies have indicated that it can improve crop productivity by 10% to 30% and water-holding capacity by 10% to 25%, particularly in soils low in nutrients

Vinaya Kumar H.M.
Vikram Patil

India’s agriculture faces a serious paradox: a large amount of biomass that could improve soil health is instead being burned. This threatens soil health and food security. Punjab and Haryana burn more than 20 million tonnes of paddy straw in their open fields every year. This is due to the short post-harvest periods and a lack of practical alternatives.

Burning these residues releases large quantities of greenhouse gases and fine particles into the air and soil, causing serious air pollution in the region as well as a major loss of organic matter that could otherwise be returned to the increasingly depleted soils.

At the same time, large tracts of agricultural land, from the black soils of Maharashtra to the red soils of Kerala, suffer from very low soil organic carbon, poor water-holding capacity, and rapid loss of nutrients, reducing crop productivity even with better seeds and irrigation.

Both these problems are symptoms of the same larger failure to recycle natural resources efficiently.

Value to agriculture

This is where biochar emerges as a carbon negative solution. Biochar is made by heating agricultural waste in low-oxygen conditions. What remains is a carbon-rich material that breaks down very slowly in the soil, helping to keep carbon locked away for long periods of time. The benefits extend well beyond carbon capture. Biochar is highly porous and contributes to aggregating soil particles, holding water, and creating a suitable environment for microorganisms.

Given these properties, the value of biochar to agriculture should be obvious. When added to poor, degraded soils, it can increase their ability to store water and stimulate the growth of beneficial microbes.

Studies have indicated that it can improve crop productivity by 10% to 30% and water-holding capacity by 10% to 25%, particularly in soils low in nutrients.

Biochar derived from maize stalks and applied to black soils in Akola district of Maharashtra has improved soil organic carbon content and overall soil fertility in field trials. Research from Kerala has shown that biochar made from coconut leaf stalks increased soil quality in different cropping systems, emphasising the need to use local resources effectively. Perhaps most significantly, long-term studies have shown that biochar has the benefit of enhancing soil health and maintaining higher crop output over time.

Wider vision

This approach also supports India’s wider vision of sustainable agriculture and climate resilience. As droughts,



A biochar mixture ready to be applied to soil. Biochar is made by heating agricultural waste in low-oxygen conditions. What remains is a carbon-rich material that breaks down very slowly in the soil. NAMIBIABCBU (CC BY)

heatwaves, and erratic rainfall become more frequent and more intense, improving soil health will be crucial to sustaining agricultural productivity.

By increasing the water-holding capacity and the ability to use nutrients efficiently, thus, biochar can help crops withstand moisture stress while reducing dependency on external inputs. This is particularly important for small and marginal farmers who are often the most exposed to the climate’s vagaries.

Integrating biochar into the existing initiatives on natural farming, soil health management, and carbon farming can deliver environmental and economic benefits at scale. Yet in India, biochar remains largely confined to research trials and pilot projects, and is very much alien to many farmers.

In fact, agricultural residues are generally seen only as a problem of disposal. But they are an important resource that can generate additional income, create jobs, can deliver environmental benefits, and could even support payments for ecosystem services.

Carbon credits

As one way forward, the government could package the activities of turning agricultural waste into biochar and putting it on soil into carbon credit markets, creating a strong economic incentive for mass adoption.

Biochar carbon already passes rigorous stability criteria for long-term sequestration, and it can be classified as a persistent carbon dioxide removal technology under internationally accepted accounting standards. For

Biochar is highly porous and contributes to aggregating soil particles, holding water, and creating a suitable environment for microorganisms

instance, VM0042 agricultural land management methodology quantifies both avoided emissions from residue burning and long-term carbon sequestration in soils. In this protocol, each tonne of certified biochar can generate 2-2.8 t carbon dioxide-equivalent in carbon credits. Depending on carbon market prices, certified biochar can thus provide an additional source of income for project developers, farmers, and cooperatives.

This approach is already being tested in projects such as those using the KISAN kiln from IIT-Kharagpur, which allows smallholders to monetise farm waste.

Several international examples also illustrate the scalability of biochar systems. In Kenya, turning rice husks into biochar has produced thousands of certified carbon credits and improved soil pH and phosphorus content. Thailand has pushed biochar use through national initiatives on soil rehabilitation and carbon management, and tied certification to access to the national carbon registry system, providing a policy-to-market pipeline. High carbon retention and large yield gains have also been reported from Brazil’s Embrapa Institute after using on-farm biochar generated from sugarcane bagasse.

These examples also show that success

depends on integrated strategies that combine decentralised, appropriately scaled pyrolysis technology with strong measurement, reporting, and verification systems.

Urban organic waste

The feedstock for biochar is also not limited to agricultural waste and can encompass urban organic waste as well. India generates around 62 million tonnes of municipal solid garbage per year and more than 50% of that is biodegradable. Sewage sludge and crop residues can also be converted into biochar.

This is in keeping with the precepts of the circular economy, as organic waste is diverted from landfills that produce methane and is converted to a useful product for agriculture. By systematically implementing these measures, India can turn its large waste streams into ‘black gold’, thus ensuring a more resilient agricultural future while making a meaningful contribution to global climate mitigation efforts.

Overall, the value of biomass can only be realised through an integrated ecosystem that catalyses innovation, entrepreneurship, market linkages, investment, and cost-effective access to biochar for farmers.

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THE GIST

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Biochar is made by heating agricultural waste in low-oxygen conditions

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Integrating biochar into the existing initiatives on natural farming, soil health management, and carbon farming can deliver environmental and economic benefits at scale

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As droughts, heatwaves, and erratic rainfall become more frequent and more intense, improving soil health will be crucial to sustaining agricultural productivity

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In India, however, biochar remains largely confined to research trials and pilot projects, and is very much alien to many farmers

BIG SHOT



People gather at the ancient stone circle Stonehenge at sunrise to celebrate the Summer Solstice, the longest day of the year, near Salisbury, England on Sunday. AP

WHAT IS IT?

No alcohol when it’s hot

Vasudevan Mukunth

In response to a new heatwave alert across Europe, France has partially banned the consumption of alcohol. The restriction is a public health measure as part of reducing heat-related illnesses.

Alcohol affects the body in many ways that become more dangerous if the person is also exposed to extreme heat. It causes the body to produce more urine, and thus increases the risk of dehydration. It impairs the body’s ability to regulate temperature by dilating blood vessels in the skin and suppressing the hormone vasopressin. And it lowers their awareness of early warning signs such as dizziness and nausea and makes them less likely to seek shade or drink water.

These risks are compounded at large outdoor events like the annual Fête de la Musique, where people may spend hours standing in crowded spaces under direct sunlight.

As Reuters reported, “After a crisis meeting, Prime Minister Sebastien Lecornu pre-emptively banned alcohol consumption on Sunday at the annual Fete de la Musique festivals and other public events” scheduled in the 35 regions with heat alerts. It added that Paris authorities had “ordered parks to remain open around the clock”. Since



A person cools off from a public fountain near the Colosseum during a heatwave in Rome. REUTERS

the city is a concrete jungle, parks could keep people cool at night.

Since the deadly 2003 heatwave in Europe, which killed nearly 15,000 people in France alone, French authorities have adopted more interventionist responses to heat, including opening cooling centres, checking on vulnerable residents, and restricting activities that could increase health risks.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Science’

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of jails in J&K to get CISF security cover

5 The Centre is set to deploy CISF security personnel to secure five more prisons of Jammu and Kashmir, following similar developments in the two central jails. A spokesperson said that “plans are under consideration” for extending the security cover of the paramilitary to the high security prison at Mahanpur and district jails of Jammu, Anantnag, Kupwara and Baramulla. PTI

Number of persons still hospitalised after food poisoning

79 Five days after a major food poisoning outbreak in Bhiwandi town of Maharashtra, 79 people continue to undergo treatment at a local hospital after consuming snacks at a popular eatery, a medical official said on Sunday. The Food and Drug Administration has launched a crackdown on food joints and sealed a prominent eatery in Thane district. PTI

Fund for modernisation of labs in Himachal medical colleges

150 ₹crore. Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu on Sunday announced a corpus of ₹150 crore for modernisation of labs in medical colleges across the State. He made the announcement after laying foundation stone of an ultra-modern critical care block on the new campus of Dr Radhakrishnan Government Medical College. PTI

Acres of eco-sensitive land in Goa notified as no-development zone

1.13 crore square metres The Goa government has issued a notification declaring nearly 1.13 crore square metres of eco-sensitive land across the coastal state as a no-development zone, officials said on Sunday. The move aims to safeguard ecological assets and prevent indiscriminate development in environmentally fragile areas, they said. PTI

Number of Naxals arrested in Jharkhand on Sunday

7 Seven Naxals, including an area commander of the banned outfit PLFI, were arrested in Jharkhand's Khunti district on Sunday, police said. People's Liberation Front of India area commander Shravan Das was injured in a gunfight with the police when he allegedly snatched a firearm and opened fire on the law enforcers in a forest. PTI

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Are footpaths more than safe spaces?

Are footpaths, as a material resource, facing a situation akin to the ‘tragedy of commons’? Have laws favoured vehicles over pedestrians? Does footpath promote equality in urban spaces? Does walking still hold significance in India? Who are responsible for protecting footpaths? Why does the court want a regulator?

EXPLAINER

Krishnadas Rajagopal

The story so far:

A Bench of Justices P.S. Narasimha and Atul S. Chandurkar has, in its judgment (Maniyar Iliyaz@Shaik Riyaz versus P. Ayyappan), said a footpath's relevance is more than that of a narrow strip of land where the ‘less-fortunate’ ones take cover from being knocked down by vehicles speeding on multi-lane motorways.

Does the ruling disconnect the footpath from the theme of accidents?

Justice Narasimha's judgment divorces the footpath from the theme of motor accidents. The sole aim of a footpath is not to avoid accidents. The pathways have an identity and a purpose of their own.

The footpath caters to the most essential, the most fundamental of rights – the pleasure of walking. The court said the presence of a broad footpath is a reflection of civilisational advancement and respect for the freedom to walk. The tracks offer the public access to urban spaces through movement by walking.

The judgment declared that the right to walk on a comfortable and safe footpath held “priority over movement by motor vehicles”. In a way, reasoning of the judgment suggests that footpaths suffer from a situation described in environmental law as the ‘tragedy of the commons’ or the degradation of a precious resource when many individuals use it. Safe and broad footpaths have become a scarce resource, riddled by encroachments, garbage and pavement trade. Secondly, the court has reasoned that broad footpaths, besides amplifying the beauty of cities, must also enable equitable access to all. Nothing should be done to thwart the public's free access to common spaces.



Sideline safety: A row of police vehicles parked on the footpath in Cubbon Park forced the pedestrians to walk on the road during IPL match in Bengaluru in April. NAGESH PRABHU

Justice Narasimha has observed that access to common spaces, in both urban areas and rural areas, should be distributed in such a way that it was “not a monopoly of the motorised class alone”. Article 39(b) of the Constitution mandates that material resources of a community must be distributed so as to sub-serve the common good. Authorities must consider the “common good” of both pedestrians and motor vehicle owner while designing a material resource like land to build roadways. A wide, well-demarcated and uninterrupted footpath could “change the beauty of and equitable access to our cities and towns”.

Does walking still hold significance in the Indian imagination?

The court said that the act of walking have had diverse roles in the Indian imagination. Walking was a struggle for the not-so-unfortunate, a meditation in motion for many, resistance for others, discovery for the inquisitive, a cohesive strategy for sharp socio-political minds.

From the first sparks which ignited the national struggle for freedom to the complexities of modern politics, the idea of walking as a means of expressing an opinion or drawing public attention remains a constant. Walking was not just motion, but embodied the fundamental freedoms of speech and expression, of peaceful protest and the right to form associations and unions for gaining the just rights of workers.

Have the ‘duty-bearers’ neglected their duty to protect footpaths?

However, laws like the Motor Vehicles Act of 1988 paid homage to movement by wheels. They even “undermined the precious rights of walkers”. Justice Narasimha said the tendency to subjugate safe and comfortable footpaths to motor transport was a civilisational problem.

The primary “duty-bearers” responsible for effectively managing footpaths are urban development authorities, municipal corporations, municipalities, and panchayats. Footpaths

are held in trust by these bodies for the public's benefit. They are the material resources of the community.

Is there a need for statutory law and regulator?

The judgment is not satisfied by merely declaring the right to walk safely on a wide and clearly demarcated footpath as a basic right, but recommends to the government to implement the fundamental right through a statutory law, and moreover, establish a regulator to hear aggrieved pedestrians.

The court recalled the positive role played by Parliament and State legislatures in the past in enabling the effective exercise and enjoyment of fundamental rights on the ground.

It also noted that modern statutes have shaped a new framework of institutional governance by creating regulatory bodies. These bodies institutionalise continuity through perpetual succession and seal, embed expertise through specialisation, promote diversity through their composition, and ensure integrity through mechanisms of accountability.

One of the examples the court drew in this context was the Right to Education Act, which had declared the fundamental right to free and compulsory elementary education under Article 21A in Sections 3 to Section 5. The National Commission for Protection of Child Rights was recognised as the regulator.

Justice Narasimha said a similar Act and a regulatory body must be devised by the legislature to protect the fundamental right to walk on demarcated footpaths. The statutory framework would not only ensure the working of the fundamental right on the ground but also identify the duty-bearers. The court said such an Act must also establish a full-time regulator to plan, enforce, and implement this precious right. The apex court has directed its Registry to send a copy of the judgment to the Central Ministries and the Law Commission of India to “reflect on the compelling necessity for initiating the necessary legal framework”.

THE GIST

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▼ The court has reasoned that broad footpaths, besides amplifying the beauty of cities, must also enable equitable access to all.

▼ The judgment is not satisfied by merely declaring the right to walk safely on a wide and clearly demarcated footpath as a basic right, but recommends to the government to implement the fundamental right through a statutory law.

Can police re-open probe without court approval?

Does Section 173(8) of CrPC permit filing of a supplementary report without Magistrate's permission?

EXPLAINER

R.K. Vij

The story so far:

The Supreme Court recently in *Paliniswamy Veeraraja & Ors. versus The State of Karnataka & Anr.* reiterated that the investigating authorities were required to obtain permission from the Magistrate to initiate further investigation after filing the closure report. In this case, the court quashed the First Information Report (FIR) and subsequent chargesheet noting that such permission had not been obtained.

Although an application seeking further investigation had been filed before the concerned Magistrate for a third time, no order granting permission was placed on record, the court said.

The investigating agency had earlier filed closure reports twice, stating that the dispute appeared to be entirely civil in nature. The court also relied on the principles laid down in *State of Haryana v. Bhajan Lal* (1992), holding that the civil nature of the dispute was an additional ground for quashing the FIR and subsequent proceedings.

Can supplementary report be filed without Magistrate's approval?

The sub-section (2) of Section 173 of the Criminal Procedure Code (CrPC) provides for forwarding a report to the Magistrate after completing investigation in the prescribed form. The Section 173(8) CrPC says that in case the in-charge of a police station finds additional evidence after sending final report to the Magistrate, he may send supplementary report to the Magistrate. It is silent on obtaining permission from a Magistrate for filing

supplementary report under sub-section (8). Section 193(9) of the BNSS is *pari materia* (dealing with the same subject matter) to Section 173(8) of the CrPC.

What has been held by the Supreme Court with regard to further investigation after filing a final report?

The Supreme Court in *Vinay Tyagi versus Irshad Ali* (2013) held that “though there is no specific requirement in the provisions of Section 173(8) of the code to conduct further investigation or file supplementary report with the leave of the court, the investigating agencies have not only understood but also adopted it as a legal practice to seek permission of the courts to conduct further investigation and file supplementary report with the leave of the court”.

The court held that the requirement of seeking prior leave of the court to

conduct further probe will have to read into, and is necessary implication of the provisions of Section 173(8) of the code. The court held that the doctrine of *contemporanea expositio* supports such an interpretation, as a practice that has been consistently understood and implemented over time, and is backed by law, should be recognised as an integral part of the interpretative process. This proposition has been approved by the Supreme Court in subsequent cases also.

While the newly added proviso to Section 193(9) of the BNSS (which is *pari materia* to Section 173(8) of the CrPC) mandates that the permission of the court is necessary if the trial has begun, the top court, in *Rama Chaudhary versus State of Bihar* (2024) reiterated that even though the statute does not require express permission, the law has developed and seeking permission from the concerned magistrate is essential. The Supreme Court, in *Robert Lalchungnunga Chongthu v. State of Bihar* (2025), reaffirmed the ratio in *Vinay Tyagi* (supra), holding that obtaining the court's leave to file a supplementary chargesheet forms an integral part of the law.

Therefore, despite the new provision of the BNSS, once a chargesheet or closure report has been filed, further probe based on new evidence may be undertaken only with the permission of the court.

R.K. Vij is a former IPS officer.

THE GIST

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